A FULL INVESTIGATION OF 40+ FITNESS PRODUCTS.

BEYOND THE LABEL

THE TRUTH BEHIND WHAT YOU'RE BUYING

BOON FAY

BEYOND THE LABEL

THE TRUTH BEHIND WHAT YOU'RE BUYING

47 PRODUCTS INVESTIGATED

FOR FAT LOSS, MUSCLE GAIN & YOUR WALLET.

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Disclaimer: This guide is for educational purposes only and is not medical advice. I'm not a doctor, dietitian or pharmacist. Talk to a qualified healthcare professional before starting any supplement, especially if you have a medical condition, take medication, or are considering anything prescription-only. Every effort has been made to keep the information accurate and up to date, but research changes and no warranty is given. Prices are estimates at the time of writing and vary by store and region.

No sponsors: No company paid to be included in this guide or to be left out of it. It contains no affiliate links or discount codes.

I'M NOT A DOCTOR

I'm a guy who wasted a lot of money.

When I was 20, I'd just lost baseball, I was 225 pounds and I hated how I looked. So I did what the internet told me to do. I bought the fat burners. The greens. The test boosters. If someone online said it worked, I bought it.

Almost none of it did.

What finally worked was boring: eating less, moving more, getting enough protein and being consistent. It took me from 225 to 175. No bottle did that for me.

Since then, I've spent years reading the research behind the products I used to buy. If you've watched my videos, you know I care about one thing: what actually works, and being honest about what doesn't.

That's what this guide is. Forty-seven products and seven trends, investigated. What the label says, what the research shows, my verdict and the cheaper thing that does the same job.

No sponsors. No affiliate links. Nobody paid to be in here, and nobody paid to stay out.

I hope it saves you the money, and the years, that I lost.

Boon

CONTENTS

STOP BUYING. START KNOWING. 7
THE PROBLEM – THE SOLUTION 9
THE NO BS BASICS 11
BASICS > BOTTLES 19
PART 1: THE TRENDS 21
HOW TO BUY WITHOUT GETTING BURNED 39
INVESTIGATION BREAKDOWN 41
PART 2: EVERY PRODUCT 43
PART 3: WHAT WORKED FOR ME 153
CLOSING WORDS 168
SOURCES 170
INDEX 174
DISCLAIMERS & CREDITS 175

☆ PART 1: THE TRENDS

100 Years of the Same Scam 23
Physique Inflation 25
The Gen Z Steroid Wave 27
The TRT Clinic Boom 29
The Peptide Craze 31
Ozempic and "Nature's Ozempic" 33
Protein in Everything 35
The Gut Health Craze 37

PART 2: EVERY PRODUCT

PROTEIN AND FOOD

Whey Protein 45
Plant Protein 47
Protein Bars and Snacks 49
Collagen 51
Mass Gainers and Meal Replacements 53

PERFORMANCE

Creatine 57
Pre-Workout 59
BCAAs and EAAs 61
Caffeine Pills 63
Beta-Alanine 65
Citrulline 67

HYDRATION

Electrolyte Packets 71
Sports Drinks 73
Prime 75

HEALTH

Greens Powders 79
Multivitamins 81
Vitamin D 83
Fish Oil 85
Magnesium 87
Probiotics 89
Ashwagandha 91
Apple Cider Vinegar Gummies 93
Sea Moss 95

FAT LOSS

Fat Burners 99
Skinny and Detox Teas 101
L-Carnitine 103
CLA 105
Berberine 107
Sweat Belts and Waist Trainers 109

HORMONES

Testosterone Boosters 113
Tongkat Ali 115
"Hormone Balancing" Supplements 117

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

Melatonin 121
ZMA 123
Cold Plunge Tubs 125
Red Light Therapy 127
Massage Guns 129
Infrared Sauna Blankets 131
Mouth Tape 133

GADGETS AND TESTS

Vibration Plates 137
"The Machine Moves for You" 139
Ab Gadgets 141
Lumen 143
Food Sensitivity Tests 145
Body Fat Scales 147
Sleep and Fitness Trackers 149
Balance Bracelets 151

BUILT FROM YEARS OF BUYING THE WRONG STUFF.

START HERE

STOP BUYING.

Most people treat supplements like a shortcut. Find the right powder, the right pill, the right drink, and the hard part gets easier.

So they keep buying. And when nothing changes, they assume they just haven't found the right one yet.

THE AIM IS TO SPEND ON WHAT WORKS AND SKIP THE REST.

START WITH WHAT'S ON YOUR SHELF You don't need to throw everything out. Look at what you already buy every month.

CHECK ONE THING Pick one product. Find its page in this guide. Read the verdict. It takes under a minute.

SWAP OR SKIP If it's worth it, keep it. If something cheaper does the same job, swap it. If it does nothing, stop buying it.

START HERE Go through the three products you spend the most on first. That's usually where most of the waste is.

That's how your shelf starts getting smaller, and your results don't change, or get better.

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THE SUPPLEMENT AISLE WASN'T BUILT FOR YOU

If you want to build muscle or lose fat, the things that work have no marketing budget.

> FROM THE LATIN **supplementum** *something that fills a gap.*

A supplement was meant to fill a gap in your diet. Not replace the diet.

THE PROBLEM

That's where the industry gets it wrong:

- Supplements in the US don't need FDA approval before they're sold. Companies can launch a product without proving it works or that it's safe.
- Marketing outspends research. A podcast ad reaches millions. A study reaches almost no one.
- The people recommending products are often paid to recommend them, through sponsorships, affiliate links or discount codes.
- Every insecurity has a product: your weight, your energy, your testosterone, your gut, your skin.

THE SOLUTION

KNOW BEFORE YOU BUY. → Check what the research says, then decide. Most of the time, the answer is cheaper than the product.

✔ This is the guide I wish I'd had at 20: 47 products and 7 trends, investigated, with a verdict and a cheaper swap for every one.

THE GOAL →

A SHELF YOU COULD DEFEND TO A SCIENTIST.

THE BASICS *Training, protein, sleep, a calorie target.*	+	**EVIDENCE** *Only buy what the research supports.*	=	**FEWER PRODUCTS** *A small, cheap shelf.*	=	**RESULTS YOU KEEP** *Progress that doesn't depend on a subscription.*

Simple. Cheap. Honest.

THE NO BS BASICS

WHAT ACTUALLY BUILDS A BODY.

I'm not going to tell you what to buy.

You don't need to know everything about supplements. You need to understand the few things that do most of the work, because no product can replace them.

The next pages cover the basics, how supplements are regulated, how to read a label and how to spot a weak study. Once you know these, half the supplement aisle stops making sense.

CALORIES
Decide if you lose, gain or maintain weight.

PROTEIN
Builds muscle and keeps it while you diet.

TRAINING
The signal that tells your body to grow.

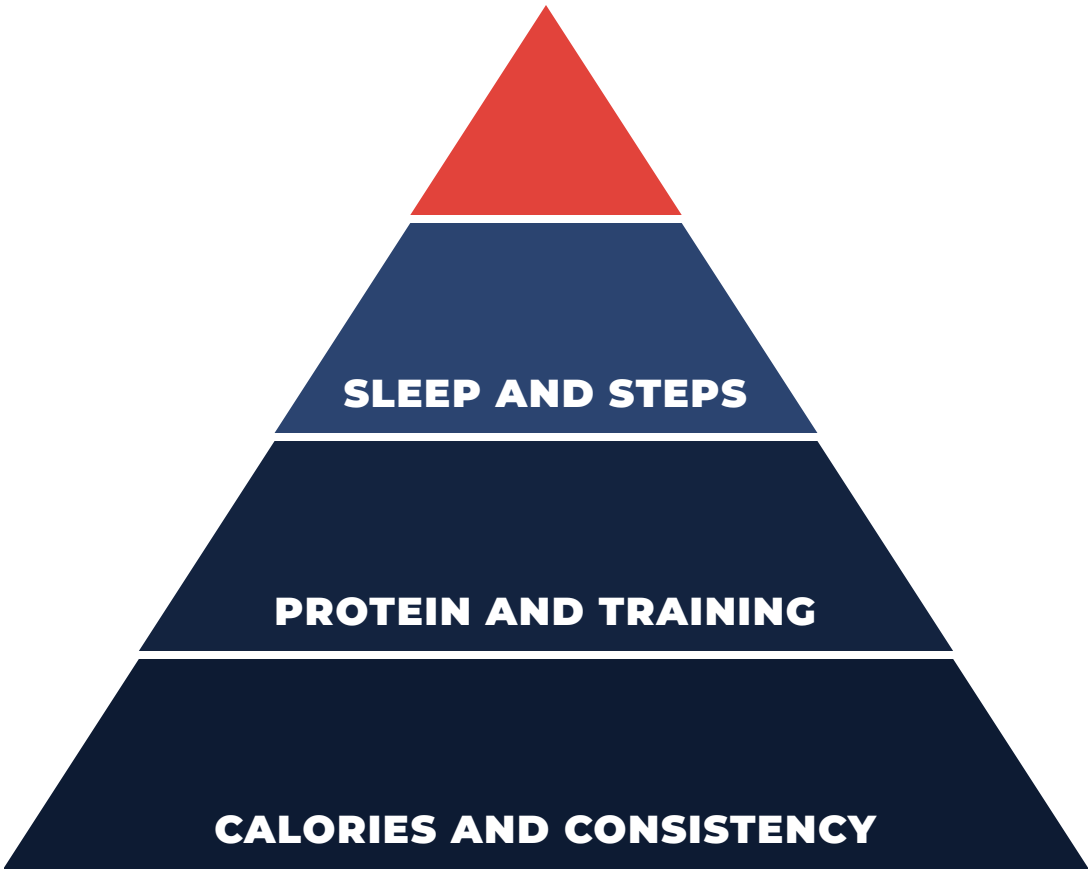
SLEEP
Where recovery and appetite control happen.

STEPS
The easiest calories you'll ever burn.

CONSISTENCY
Beats every product in this guide.

THE PYRAMID.

SUPPLEMENTS ARE THE TIP, NOT THE BASE.



↑ SUPPLEMENTS LIVE UP HERE

1. **Calories and consistency.** This decides whether your weight goes up, down or stays the same.
2. **Protein and training.** This decides whether the weight you lose is fat or muscle, and whether you build any.
3. **Sleep and steps.** Recovery, appetite and the easy calories that add up.
4. **Supplements.** A few cheap ones can help. They only matter once everything below is in place.

If the base is missing, the tip falls over.

WHERE YOUR MONEY SHOULD GO

THE BASIC	WHAT IT COSTS	WHAT IT DOES
A calorie target	Free (any calculator app)	Controls fat loss or gain
Enough protein	Your normal grocery bill	Builds and protects muscle
Lifting 3–4 times a week	A gym membership or bodyweight	Tells your body to build muscle
7–9 hours of sleep	Free	Recovery, mood, appetite
Walking	Free	Burns calories without wrecking recovery

THE NUMBERS THAT MATTER (APPROX.)

- **Protein:** about 1.6–2.2 g per kg of body weight a day (0.7–1.0 g per lb). For a 180 lb guy, that's roughly 125–180 g. (Morton et al., 2018)
- **Fat loss:** aim to lose about 0.5–1% of your body weight a week. Faster usually costs muscle and sanity.
- **Muscle gain:** a small surplus, roughly 200–300 calories over maintenance. Gaining faster mostly adds fat.
- **Sleep:** 7–9 hours for most adults.

If you're underweight, have a medical condition or have a history of disordered eating, talk to a doctor or registered dietitian before changing how you eat.

WHO CHECKS THIS STUFF?

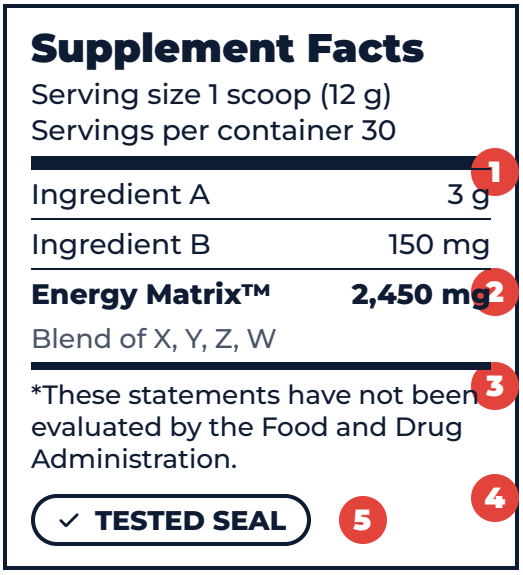
SHORT ANSWER: NOT WHO YOU THINK.

In the US, a 1994 law, the Dietary Supplement Health and Education Act, set the rules. Here's what it means for you:

- **No approval before sale.** Supplements don't need FDA approval to go on the shelf. Drugs do.
- **The company is responsible for safety,** not the government. The FDA usually acts after problems are reported.
- **Vague claims are allowed.** "Supports energy" or "supports testosterone" is legal. "Treats low testosterone" isn't.
- **The asterisk.** Ever seen "*These statements have not been evaluated by the Food and Drug Administration"? That's the label telling you, in small print, that nobody checked the claim on the front.

"Supports" is the most expensive word in fitness.

HOW TO READ A LABEL IN 30 SECONDS



1. **Serving size.** Is the dose for one scoop or three? Check how many servings you really get.
2. **The dose of each ingredient.** Compare it with the dose used in studies. Many products contain an ingredient but nowhere near enough of it.
3. **Proprietary blend.** A list of ingredients with one total weight. You can't tell how much of each you're getting. That's a red flag.
4. **The asterisk.** If a claim has an asterisk, nobody had to prove it.
5. **Third-party seal.** NSF Certified for Sport, Informed Sport or BSCG means an independent lab tested it for banned and hidden substances.

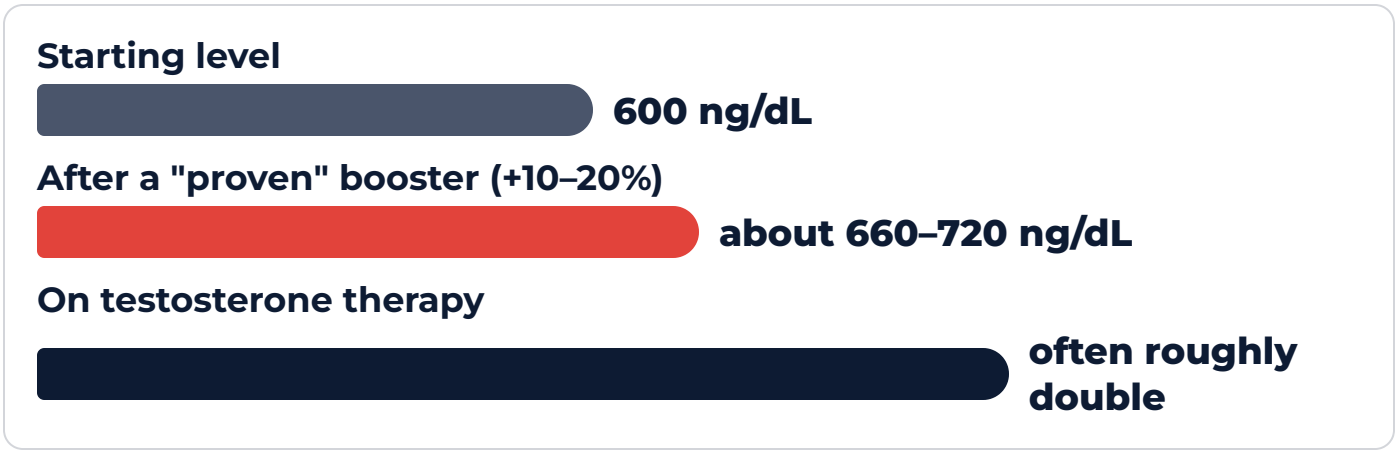
"CLINICALLY PROVEN."

What it usually means, and what it doesn't.

Every bottle says it's backed by science. Here's how to tell if it actually is.

ASK THIS	WHY IT MATTERS
Was it done in humans?	Lots of supplement claims come from rats or cells in a dish. Those results often don't carry over to people.
How many people?	A study of 12 people is a starting point, not proof.
Who paid for it?	Company-funded studies aren't automatically wrong, but they deserve a second look.
Who was studied?	A result in sick or deficient people doesn't mean it works for healthy guys who lift.
How big was the effect?	"Statistically significant" can still be too small to notice.
Does the product use the same dose?	A study dose of 6 grams means nothing if your scoop has 500 milligrams.

SIGNIFICANT VS. MEANINGFUL



The booster's result can be "statistically significant" and still be a change you'd never feel in the gym.

HOW I RATE THE EVIDENCE

▬▬▬	**Strong (3 bars).** many good human studies agree.
▬▬	**Moderate (2 bars).** some good human studies, but with limits or mixed results.
▬	**Weak (1 bar).** mostly animal studies, tiny studies or company marketing.

BASICS > BOTTLES

For a couple of years, the Liver King was everywhere. Shirtless, eating raw organs on camera, telling millions of guys his body came from "ancestral living," and selling supplements to help you do the same.

In late 2022, leaked emails to a bodybuilding coach showed him spending roughly $11,000 to $12,000 a month on growth hormone and steroids. Days later, he posted an apology video and admitted to steroid use. Customers later filed a lawsuit over his supplement marketing.

The physique was the ad.

People didn't fail because they lacked discipline. They were comparing their natural body to someone else's chemistry, and buying the product that supposedly built it.

THE LESSON: THE PHYSIQUE IS THE AD.

MAKE THE CHEAP OPTION THE DEFAULT

> **"Nothing I bought got me from 225 to 175. The basics did." — Boon**

BUILD BETTER DEFAULTS

- **PICK YOUR BASICS:** a calorie target, a protein target and a training schedule you'll actually follow.
- **KEEP IT BORING:** two or three supplements with strong evidence beat a shelf full of maybes.
- **ADD ONE THING AT A TIME:** if you add five products at once, you'll never know which one did anything.
- **CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY:** find the product's page in this guide first.

When the basics are in place, you need much less from a bottle.

PART 1: THE TRENDS

100 YEARS OF THE SAME SCAM 23

PHYSIQUE INFLATION 25

THE GEN Z STEROID WAVE 27

THE TRT CLINIC BOOM 29

THE PEPTIDE CRAZE 31

OZEMPIC AND "NATURE'S OZEMPIC" 33

PROTEIN IN EVERYTHING 35

THE GUT HEALTH CRAZE 37

THE TRENDS

100 YEARS OF THE SAME SCAM

In the 1920s, people strapped a vibrating belt around their waist and stood there while it shook them. The promise? Jiggle the fat away. It did nothing.

Now open TikTok. Vibration plates. Same promise. Stand on it, shake, lose fat.

The product changes every decade. The trick never does.

1920S	**Vibrating belt machines** *"Jiggle the fat away"*
1960S	**One-minute isometric gadgets** *"An athlete's physique, without sweat"*
1970S	**Sauna suits** *"Sweat away the pounds"*
1980S–90S	**Ephedra diet and energy pills** *Energy and fat loss*
1990S–2000S	**Ab gadgets and the Shake Weight** *"Abs in minutes a day"*
2010S	**"Performance" bracelets** *Better balance and strength*
2020S	**Vibration plates, "nature's Ozempic," research peptides** *All of the above*

THE PATTERN

1. Take a real worry: your weight, your energy, your body.
2. Sell something next to the real solution.
3. Make it sound easier than the real thing.
4. Charge a premium for it.

If any of these worked the way they claimed, we wouldn't need a new one every ten years.

Once you see the pattern, you can't unsee it. Every trend that follows uses some version of it.

PHYSIQUE INFLATION

WHY NOBODY LOOKS GOOD ENOUGH ANYMORE.

A great body from ten years ago now gets called "mid" in the comments. That's physique inflation, and it's one of the biggest reasons guys quit, or go looking for shortcuts.

HOW IT HAPPENED

- Your algorithm shows you the most extreme bodies on the planet, because those get the most attention.
- The photos use tricks: a pump before the shot, lighting from above, flexed angles, days of cutting water.
- Some of those guys are enhanced and say they're not.
- Without noticing, the top 1% becomes your idea of normal.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

- A 1995 study comparing natural lifters with steroid users found a ceiling on how much muscle a natural lifter carries for his height. Many "natural" physiques online sit well past it. (Kouri et al., 1995)
- In an experiment with 197 young men, body satisfaction dropped after viewing muscular Instagram images, but not after slim, average or landscape images. (Siena, 2020)
- A 2024 University of South Australia study found that guys who cared most about likes and comments on their posts showed more signs of muscle dysmorphia: feeling too small no matter how big you get.

Big stat callout: The average American man is about **5'9"**, around **200 lbs**, with a **40-inch waist** (CDC data).

THE VERDICT

The standard you're comparing yourself to was never real.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

- Unfollow accounts that make you feel worse and teach you nothing.
- Compare yourself only to your own photos and your own lifts.
- Take progress photos in the same light, same time of day, relaxed.
- Give it years, not months. That's how natural bodies are built.

THE GEN Z STEROID WAVE

Steroids used to be a secret. Now they're content.

Teenagers post themselves injecting in the gym, and it gets millions of views. To a 16-year-old scrolling at midnight, it doesn't look dangerous. It looks normal.

HOW BIG THIS GOT

A 2023 report by the Center for Countering Digital Hate found steroid-related TikTok videos drew more than **587 million** US views over three years, and about **72%** of those views came from users aged 18 to 24. (CCDH, 2023)

WHY IT LOOKS SAFE ONLINE

You only see the guys it worked for. You don't see the acne scars, the shut-down hormones or the guys who quit and crashed. That's survivorship bias: the winners post, and everyone else goes quiet.

SARMS: THE "LEGAL" LOOPHOLE

SARMs are sold as safer steroid alternatives, often labeled "for research only" or "not for human consumption" to dodge the rules. They aren't FDA-approved, and they come with steroid-like side effects, including shutting down your own testosterone.

THE REAL RISKS, ESPECIALLY FOR YOUNGER GUYS

RISK	WHAT IT MEANS
Hormone shutdown	Your body stops making its own testosterone. Coming off can mean fatigue, depression and fertility problems.
Gyno, acne, hair loss	Common, and some of it doesn't go away.
Heart strain	Steroids can enlarge the heart muscle over time.
Growth plates	In teenagers, some steroids can stop growth early.
Black market quality	No quality control. What's in the vial may not match the label.

A STORY WORTH KNOWING: Taylor Hooton was a 17-year-old high school baseball player who used steroids to try to make varsity. He died by suicide in 2003, and his family believes steroid withdrawal played a role. His parents started the Taylor Hooton Foundation to educate kids about the risks.

> If you're struggling, you're not alone. In the US, call or text 988 to reach the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline.

THE VERDICT

If you're young and natural, you have years of progress ahead of you. Most guys who start early never end up looking like the people who influenced them.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD: Train hard for three to five years before you even think about it. Eat enough protein, sleep and be patient. If you think your hormones are actually off, get blood work and see a real doctor.

THE TRT CLINIC BOOM

A real treatment, sold like a subscription.

Testosterone replacement therapy is a real medical treatment. For men who genuinely have low testosterone, it can change their lives. The problem is everyone else getting it.

HOW IT BECAME A TREND

- Online clinics made it easy: fill out a questionnaire, do a quick blood test, get a prescription.
- The questions describe almost everyone: "Do you feel tired?" "Is your mood low?"
- Celebrities and fitness influencers talk about it openly, often with a clinic to recommend.

THE STUDY THAT SAYS IT ALL

In a secret-shopper study published in *JAMA Internal Medicine*, researchers posed as a 34-year-old man with normal testosterone levels who wanted to have kids in the future. **Six of the seven** online platforms still offered him testosterone. (Northwestern Medicine, 2023)

That matters because testosterone therapy suppresses sperm production. For a guy who wants kids, starting without a plan from a specialist is exactly the wrong move.

Big stat callout: Normal testosterone for men sits roughly between **300 and 1,000 ng/dL.** Some guys on "TRT" are dosed well above that. At that point, it's not replacement anymore. It's enhancement with a prescription.

THE RISKS: lower fertility, acne, hair loss, thicker blood and, for some guys, a lifelong dependence because natural production shuts down. It can also hide a real problem. If your testosterone is low at 25, a good doctor wants to know *why*: sleep apnea, obesity, medications or a pituitary issue could be the cause.

THE VERDICT

Worth it if you truly need it, diagnosed properly by a doctor who isn't paid only when you say yes. For most healthy young guys who are just tired, it's a shortcut that can cost a lot later.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

1. Fix the basics first: 7–9 hours of sleep, lose excess fat, lift, eat enough and manage stress.
2. Still have symptoms? Get a morning blood test, ideally on two separate days.
3. See an endocrinologist or urologist, not just an online clinic.

THE PEPTIDE CRAZE

Miracle vials with almost no human data.

Depending on who you ask, injectable peptides will heal any injury, melt fat and make you look ten years younger. The research says we mostly don't know yet.

WHAT PEPTIDES ARE

Peptides are short chains of amino acids your body already uses as signals. Some are proven, approved medicines, like insulin and the GLP-1 drugs behind Ozempic. The ones trending online, like BPC-157, are a different story: mostly studied in animals, with little solid human research.

HOW THEY'RE SOLD

In 2023, the FDA restricted many popular peptides, including BPC-157, from being made by compounding pharmacies, citing safety concerns and a lack of human data. So sellers use the same loophole as SARMs: "for research purposes only." Then influencers with affiliate links explain how to inject it.

THE PROBLEMS

PROBLEM	WHY IT MATTERS
Mostly animal research	Results in rats often don't carry over to people.
Unverified labs	Many vials come from overseas suppliers with no oversight.
Dose roulette	Independent testing has found products with far more or far less than the label says.
"No side effects"	Usually means nobody has studied the side effects yet.

THE VERDICT

Waste of money, and a real risk, for unapproved research peptides. Approved peptide medicines are a different category and belong with a doctor.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD: For an injury, see a physical therapist. For fat loss, a calorie deficit and protein. For skin, sunscreen and a retinoid. Boring, cheap and backed by human data.

OZEMPIC & "NATURE'S OZEMPIC"

The drug works. That's why the hype around it is so slippery.

WHAT IT IS

Ozempic is semaglutide, a GLP-1 drug first approved for type 2 diabetes. The weight-loss version is Wegovy. It copies a hormone that tells your brain you're full and slows how fast your stomach empties, so you eat less without white-knuckling it.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

- In the main clinical trials, people lost around **15%** of their body weight.
- In the real world, results have been smaller, mostly because many people stop taking it.
- When people stop, a lot of the weight tends to come back. For many, it works more like a subscription than a cure.

WHERE THE SCAM IS

- **No-prescription sellers:** products ordered without a prescription have turned up contaminated, wrongly dosed or never delivered.
- **Prescription mills:** when a business only gets paid if the answer is yes, the screening isn't really screening.
- **"Nature's Ozempic":** berberine, apple cider vinegar gummies and fiber pills. Some foods nudge the same fullness hormone, but nowhere near the drug. See Berberine, page 107.

THE VERDICT

Worth it as a prescribed medication when weight is a real medical issue. Waste of money for knockoffs and "natural" versions.

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD: If your weight is a genuine health problem, talk to a doctor, including about official cash-price programs. If you want to lose 15 pounds, a calorie deficit, protein at every meal and walking will get you there, and you'll keep the result.

PROTEIN IN EVERYTHING

Protein is useful. A protein label isn't proof.

Protein cereal. Protein chips. Protein pasta, coffee and pancakes. Protein genuinely matters, so food companies figured out the word sells.

THE LABEL LOOPHOLE

In the US, protein claims are measured against a daily value of just 50 grams.

THE FRONT OF THE BOX SAYS	MINIMUM PROTEIN NEEDED PER SERVING
"Good source of protein"	5 g
"High protein"	10 g

Most guys who lift are aiming for well over 100 grams a day. So "high protein" can mean 10 grams floating in 300 calories of sugar and oil.

THE OTHER TRICKS

- × "Protein packed" and "protein plus" have no legal definition.
- × "With milk": some cereals and shakes count the milk's protein in the big number.
- × Comparing to junk: "twice the protein of a candy bar" isn't saying much.

WHEN LABELS DON'T MATCH

- **Lenny & Larry's** agreed to a $5 million proposed settlement in 2018 over claims its cookies had less protein than advertised, while denying wrongdoing and standing by its labeling. (FoodNavigator-USA, 2018)
- **Cheerios Protein** was sued in 2015 by a consumer group that said the protein version carried far more sugar than the original.

THE VERDICT
Protein products aren't a scam. The premium is.

THE CALORIE TEST

Take the calories, drop the last zero and compare. If the grams of protein beat that number, it's a solid pick.

- 190 calories, 20 g protein: 20 beats 19. **Good.**
- 480 calories, 16 g protein: 16 loses to 48. **Candy with a protein sticker.**

THE GUT HEALTH CRAZE

"Heal your gut" is a marketing phrase, not a diagnosis.

It's on greens powders, probiotics, detox teas and gummies. Gut health is real and important. The marketing around it mostly isn't.

WHY IT SELLS

Almost everyone has felt bloated after a meal. And gut science is genuinely complex: hundreds of species of bacteria, still poorly understood. Complex and important is a marketer's dream, because it's easy to claim one product fixes everything when nobody fully understands the system.

THE BEFORE-AND-AFTER TRICK

A lot of "bloat" photos are just a stomach with food in it. Of course it looks bigger after you eat. That's not a disease.

THE VERDICT

Waste of money for most "gut healing" products.

FREE FIXES FOR EVERYDAY BLOATING

01

Fiber from many plants fruit, vegetables, beans and whole grains. Increase it slowly.

02

Water through the day

03

A 10-minute walk after big meals.

04

Fewer fizzy drinks and less gum, which make you swallow air.

If your symptoms are severe, constant or getting worse, see a doctor. That's not something to fix with a supplement.

HOW TO BUY WITHOUT GETTING BURNED

Remember: supplements aren't approved before they're sold. The FDA usually steps in after people get hurt. Here's what that has looked like.

2003–2004 Ephedra (fat burners, early pre-workouts)
Linked to heart attacks, strokes and deaths, including Orioles pitcher Steve Bechler in 2003. Banned by the FDA in 2004.

BANNED

2012–2013 DMAA (Jack3d and other pre-workouts)
Linked to the death of marathon runner Claire Squires in 2012. The FDA moved to get it off the market by 2013.

RECALLED

2013 Craze pre-workout
Tests found a methamphetamine-like compound that wasn't on the label.

RECALLED

2013 Purity First vitamin B-50
FDA testing found anabolic steroids in a vitamin.

RECALLED

1938–today DNP ("fat burner")
Banned for human use since 1938, still sold online. Eloise Parry, 21, died after taking it in 2015. The seller was jailed for seven years.

BANNED

How common is this? A 2018 analysis in *JAMA Network Open* found 776 supplements flagged by the FDA for hidden drugs over about ten years. Most were sold for weight loss, sexual enhancement or muscle building.

THE PATTERN: the riskiest products look the most "hardcore." Extreme energy. Rapid fat loss. "Anabolic."

5 RULES BEFORE YOU BUY

1 **LOOK FOR A SEAL**
NSF Certified for Sport, Informed Sport or BSCG. An independent lab tested it.

2 **AVOID PROPRIETARY BLENDS**
if they won't tell you the dose, you can't judge it.

3 **SKIP WHAT YOU CAN'T PRONOUNCE**
especially stimulants with chemical-sounding names.

4 **RUN FROM "RESEARCH ONLY"**
"not for human consumption" means exactly that.

5 **ONLY BUY WHAT YOU NEED**
every product you don't take is a risk you don't carry.

INVESTIGATION BREAKDOWN

Here's what you'll find on every product.

01 **AT A GLANCE**
The category, the product, a one-line summary and the sticker with the verdict, evidence and typical cost.

02 **THE CLAIM**
What the label or the ads promise you, in their words.

03 **WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS**
What the studies actually show, with the source in brackets.

04 **MARKETING VS. REALITY**
The thinking behind the verdict: what they say on the left, what's true on the right.

USE IT YOUR WAY

You don't need to read this cover to cover. Find the products on your shelf, read their pages, and decide. If a product is "situational," read the fine print, because it might be the right call for you.

Every product follows the same layout, so you can spend less time decoding it and more time deciding.

05 **THE PRODUCT**
A photo of the real thing, so you know exactly what we're talking about. All photos are my own.

06 **THE BADGES**
Verdict, evidence, typical cost per month, what you could save, and the swap. Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PROTEIN AND FOOD

WHEY PROTEIN 45

PLANT PROTEIN 47

PROTEIN BARS AND SNACKS 49

COLLAGEN 51

MASS GAINERS AND MEAL REPLACEMENTS 53

PROTEIN

29
SERVINGS
OPTIMUM
NUTRITION
GOLD STANDARD
100% WHEY
PROTEIN
FOR MUSCLE SUPPORT & RECOVERY
24G PROTEIN PER SERVING
VANILLA ICE CREAM
ARTIFICIALLY FLAVORED
PROTEIN POWDER DRINK MIX NET WT 31.7 OZ (1.98 LB) 899 G 29 SERVINGS

PROTEIN AND FOOD

WHEY PROTEIN

VERDICT
WORTH IT
EVIDENCE
STRONG
COST
$50/MO

FOOD IN A TUB, AND THAT'S THE POINT

Whey is a complete, high-quality protein that digests fast. It's not magic, but it's one of the easiest ways to hit your protein target on a busy day.

☆ THE CLAIM

“Builds muscle, speeds recovery, "anabolic" results.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Protein intake, from any source, supports muscle growth when you lift. Gains tend to level off around 1.6 g per kg of body weight per day. Whey is a convenient, high-quality way to get there. (Morton et al., 2018)

⇄ THE SWAP

A plain whey with a third-party seal. Whey isolate costs more and mainly helps if regular whey bothers your stomach.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Anabolic formula"~~	→	✓ **It's protein. Your total daily intake is what matters.**
× ~~"Advanced blend"~~	→	✓ **Often regular whey with added buzzwords.**
× ~~"Post-workout window"~~	→	✓ **Hitting your daily total matters far more than timing.**

WHEY PROTEIN

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Worth it	Strong	$50	Skip the "premium" blends	Plain whey, third-party tested

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PROTEIN AND FOOD

PLANT PROTEIN

GOOD IF YOU NEED IT, NOT "BETTER" IF YOU DON'T

If you don't eat dairy, plant protein does the job. Just don't pay extra for the "superfood" add-ins.

VERDICT
WORTH IT (IF YOU NEED IT)
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$45/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Just as good as whey, cleaner and healthier."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Single plant proteins can be lower in some essential amino acids, but blends, such as pea and rice, cover that well. Soy is a complete protein on its own. Hit the same daily total and results look similar.

⇄ THE SWAP

If you eat dairy, whey is usually cheaper per gram. If you don't, a pea-and-rice blend.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Superfood blend"~~	→	✓ **"Superfood" has no legal definition.**
× ~~"Cleaner than whey"~~	→	✓ **Both can be clean. Look for a third-party seal.**
× ~~"Better for digestion"~~	→	✓ **Only if dairy is the problem for you.**

PLANT PROTEIN

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Worth it	Moderate	$45	Skip superfood add-ins	Pea-and-rice blend, or whey

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PROTEIN AND FOOD

PROTEIN BARS AND SNACKS

SOME ARE FOOD. SOME ARE CANDY IN DISGUISE.

A good bar is a handy backup. A bad one is a candy bar that charges you extra for 10 grams of protein.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$2.10 PER BAR

☆ THE CLAIM

"A healthy, high-protein snack."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

US labels can say "high protein" with just 10 grams per serving, measured against a 50 g daily value. Many bars rely on sugar, sugar alcohols and oils to taste good. See Protein in Everything, page 35.

⇌ THE SWAP

Use the calorie test: drop the last zero from the calories, and the protein should beat it. Greek yogurt, jerky, eggs, cottage cheese or a shake usually win.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"High protein"~~	→	✓ **Can legally mean 10 g.**
× ~~"Guilt-free"~~	→	✓ **Calories still count.**
× ~~"Protein packed"~~	→	✓ **No legal definition at all.**

PROTEIN BARS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$63	The "protein" premium	⇄ Greek yogurt, jerky, eggs

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PROTEIN AND FOOD

COLLAGEN

IT DOESN'T GO STRAIGHT TO YOUR SKIN

Collagen is a protein, and your body breaks it down like any other. Eating collagen doesn't mean it ends up where the ad says it will.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
WEAK TO MODERATE
COST
$42/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Better skin, hair, nails and joints."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Some small studies show modest skin and joint benefits, but many are industry-funded. For building muscle, collagen is a low-quality protein because it's missing key amino acids.

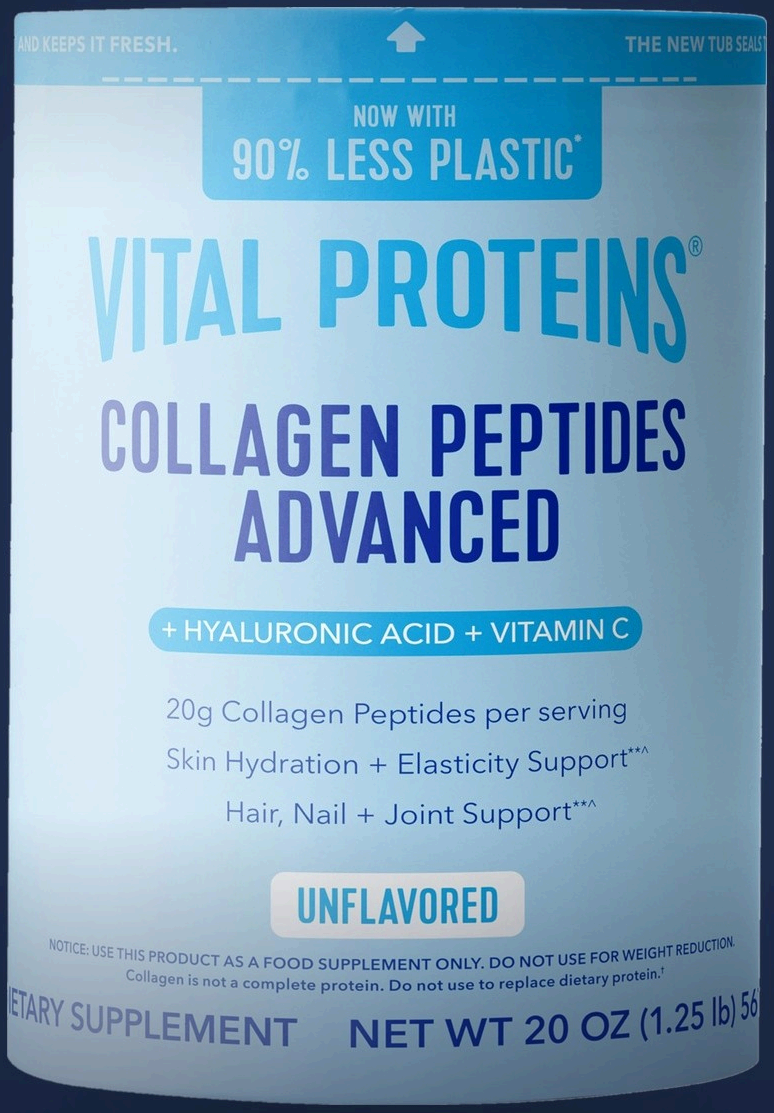
⇄ THE SWAP

For skin, daily sunscreen and a retinoid. For muscle, whey.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Rebuilds your collagen"~~	→	✓ **It's digested into amino acids first.**
× ~~"Counts toward your protein"~~	→	✓ **It does, but it's a weak protein for muscle.**
× ~~"Gummies with collagen"~~	→	✓ **Some contain tiny amounts. Check the dose.**

COLLAGEN



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Weak–moderate	$42	Most of the tub	⇄ Sunscreen for skin, whey for muscle

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PROTEIN AND FOOD

MASS GAINERS AND MEAL REPLACEMENTS

MOSTLY CHEAP CARBS AT A PREMIUM

A mass gainer is mostly sugar or maltodextrin plus some protein. A meal replacement can help in a pinch, but check what's actually in the powder.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$120–240/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Easy gains, or a complete meal in a bottle."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Gaining weight comes down to eating more calories than you burn. A gainer is just a convenient, expensive way to do that. Some meal replacements advertise protein "with milk" while the powder itself has very little.

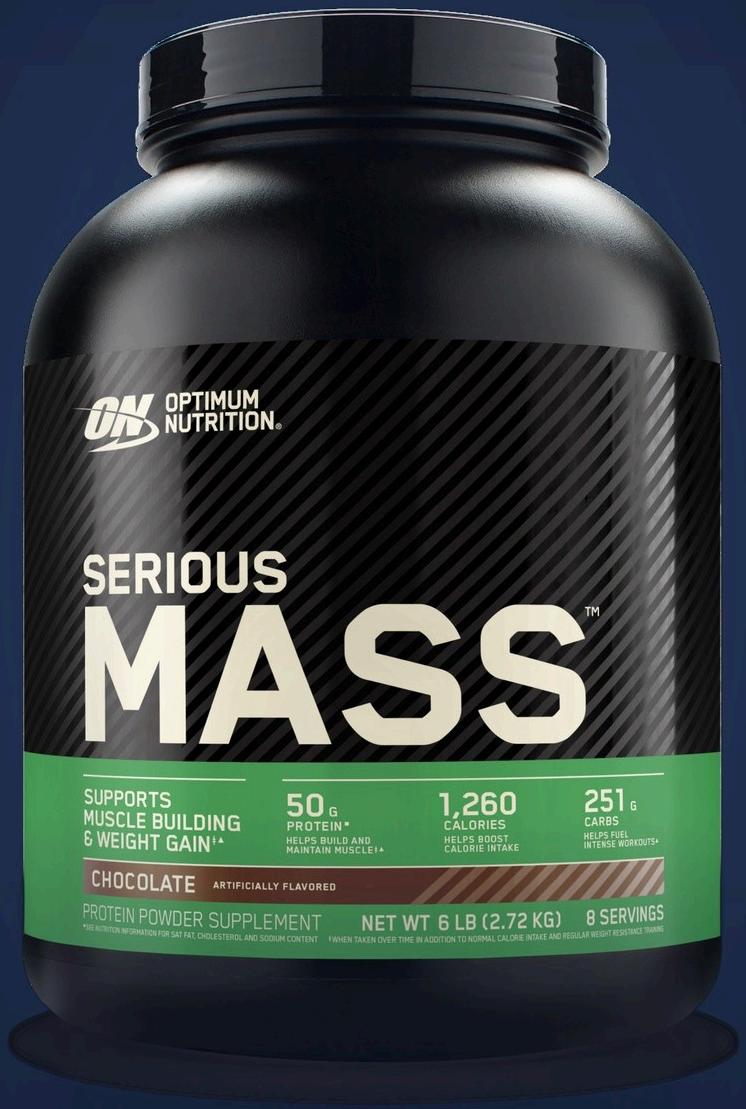
⇄ THE SWAP

Blend your own: milk, oats, a banana, peanut butter and a scoop of whey. More protein and calories for less money.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"1,250 calories per serving"~~	→	✓ **Mostly cheap carbs.**
× ~~"Complete nutrition"~~	→	✓ **Read the label without the milk.**
× ~~"Lean gains"~~	→	✓ **Gaining fast mostly adds fat.**

MASS GAINERS



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$120–240	Most of the gainer price	⇄ Homemade shake

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

CREATINE 57

PRE-WORKOUT 59

BCAAS AND EAAS 61

CAFFEINE PILLS 63

BETA-ALANINE 65

CITRULLINE 67

PERFORMANCE

PERFORMANCE

CREATINE

THE CHEAP ONE IS THE ONE THAT WORKS

One of the most researched supplements there is. The only mistake is paying extra for a fancy version.

VERDICT
WORTH IT
EVIDENCE
STRONG
COST
ABOUT $6–12/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

“More strength and muscle. Fancy versions add "advanced absorption" and results "from the first dose.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Creatine monohydrate consistently improves strength and muscle gains when paired with training, and it has a strong safety record in healthy people. (Kreider et al., 2017) Creatine builds up in your muscles over a few weeks, so you won't feel it on day one. A head-to-head study found creatine ethyl ester, a "premium" form, worked worse than plain monohydrate. Some people naturally have high creatine levels and notice less.

⇄ THE SWAP

Plain, unflavored, third-party-tested creatine monohydrate. 3–5 g a day, every day, any time.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Advanced absorption"~~	→	✓ **Monohydrate is the proven form.**
× ~~"Feel it on day one"~~	→	✓ **It takes a few weeks to build up.**
× ~~"Loading phase required"~~	→	✓ **Optional. 3–5 g daily gets you there, just slower.**

CREATINE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Worth it	Strong	$6–12	Skip "advanced" forms	Plain monohydrate

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

PRE-WORKOUT

YOU'RE MOSTLY PAYING FOR CAFFEINE

I'll be honest, I like pre-workout. But I know exactly what I'm paying for.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
STRONG (FOR CAFFEINE)
COST
ABOUT $35 A TUB

☆ THE CLAIM

"Explosive energy, insane pumps, laser focus."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Caffeine is the ingredient doing most of the work, and it has strong evidence. (Guest et al., 2021) The tingle is beta-alanine, a harmless side effect, not a sign it's working. Many tubs hide doses in proprietary blends, and pre-workouts have a history of banned stimulants like ephedra and DMAA. See page 39.

⇄ THE SWAP

A coffee 30 minutes before training. If you like pre-workout, choose a fully disclosed label with a third-party seal.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Explosive energy"~~	→	✓ **Mostly caffeine.**
× ~~"The tingle means it's working"~~	→	✓ **It's a side effect of beta-alanine.**
× ~~"Proprietary energy matrix"~~	→	✓ **You can't check the doses.**

PRE-WORKOUT

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Strong (caffeine)	About $35	Most of the tub	⇄ Coffee

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

BCAAS AND EAAS

WATERING YOUR LAWN WHILE IT'S RAINING

If you already eat enough protein, these add basically nothing.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK (IF YOU EAT ENOUGH PROTEIN)

COST
$27/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Builds muscle, prevents breakdown, speeds recovery."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

BCAAs are three of the amino acids found in protein. On their own, they can't build muscle, because your body needs all the essential amino acids to do that. Benefits mostly show up when people aren't eating enough protein. EAAs are a more complete product, but the same rule applies: hit your protein and they add little.

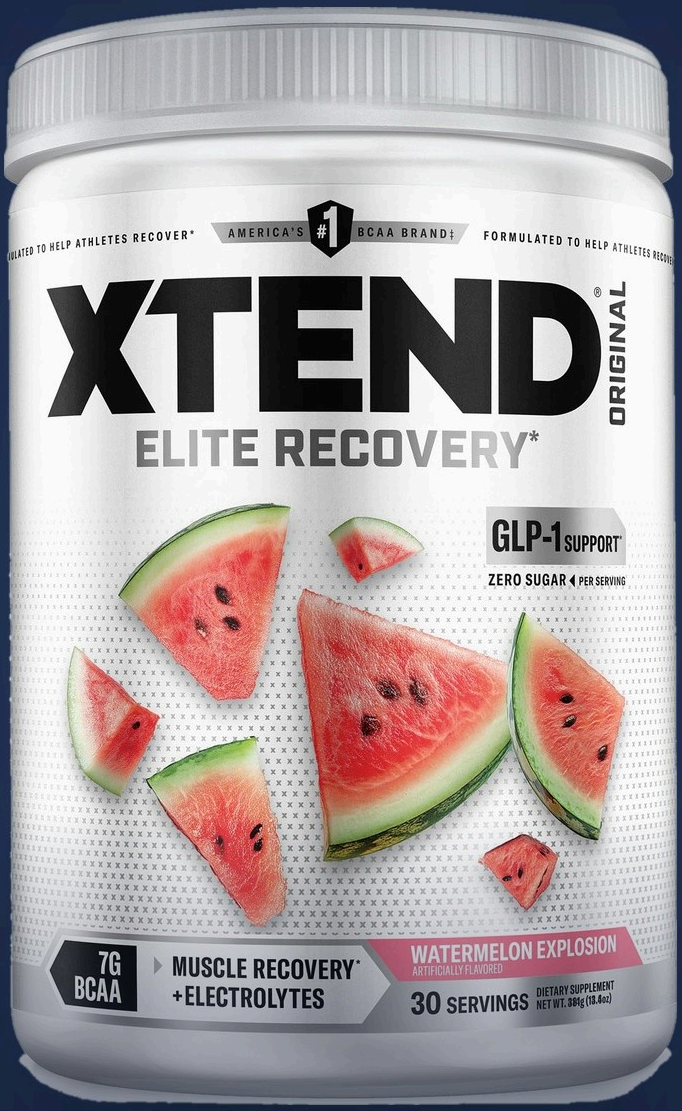
⇄ THE SWAP

Hit your daily protein. If you just like flavored water, a cheap water flavoring does the same job.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Prevents muscle breakdown"~~	→	✓ **Only matters if your protein is low.**
× ~~"Intra-workout recovery"~~	→	✓ **Your post-workout meal covers it.**
× ~~"Zero calories, all gains"~~	→	✓ **Mostly flavored water.**

BCAAS



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$27	The whole tub	⇄ Hit your protein

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

CAFFEINE PILLS

ONE OF THE FEW THINGS THAT REALLY WORKS

Caffeine has some of the best evidence of any performance supplement. You just don't need a fancy version of it.

VERDICT
WORTH IT
EVIDENCE
STRONG
COST
A FEW DOLLARS A MONTH

☆ THE CLAIM

"More energy, more focus, better performance."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Caffeine reliably improves performance for many people. Studies typically use about 3–6 mg per kg of body weight, 30–60 minutes before exercise. (Guest et al., 2021) More isn't better: high doses cause jitters, anxiety and wrecked sleep.

⇄ THE SWAP

Coffee works just as well. Pills are handy if you don't like coffee or want an exact dose.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Thermogenic energy"~~	→	✓ **It's caffeine, with a tiny calorie burn.**
× ~~"Clean energy blend"~~	→	✓ **Still caffeine. Check the total.**
× ~~"Take it any time"~~	→	✓ **Avoid it within about 8 hours of bed.**

CAFFEINE

Don't stack caffeine pills with pre-workout and energy drinks. Talk to a doctor first if you have heart issues or anxiety.

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Worth it	Strong	A few dollars	Branded "energy" blends	Coffee

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

BETA-ALANINE

THE TINGLE IN YOUR PRE-WORKOUT

It does something, just not for most of what guys use it for.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$6/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"More endurance and more reps."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Beta-alanine helps most with hard efforts lasting about one to four minutes, like high-rep sets, sprints or conditioning. It does little for heavy, low-rep strength. It builds up over weeks, and the tingle is harmless. (Trexler et al., 2015)

⇄ THE SWAP

If you mostly lift heavy for sets of five, skip it. If you do a lot of high-rep or conditioning work, plain beta-alanine powder is cheaper than paying for it in a pre-workout.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Strength and power"~~	→	✓ **Helps endurance in 1–4 minute efforts.**
× ~~"Feel it working"~~	→	✓ **The tingle is a side effect.**
× ~~"One scoop, instant results"~~	→	✓ **Builds up over several weeks.**

BETA-ALANINE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$6	Skip it for heavy lifting	⇄ Plain powder if needed

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PERFORMANCE

CITRULLINE

THE "PUMP" INGREDIENT

Some evidence, small effects, and often underdosed.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
WEAK TO MODERATE
COST
$26/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Bigger pumps, better blood flow, more reps."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Some studies show small improvements in reps and fatigue, but results are mixed. Studies usually use several grams of citrulline malate, and many "pump" products contain much less.

⇄ THE SWAP

If you want it, buy plain citrulline and use a study-sized dose, instead of a "nitric oxide booster" built around a tiny one.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Skin-splitting pumps"~~	→	✓ **The pump is temporary and doesn't equal growth.**
× ~~"Nitric oxide booster"~~	→	✓ **Often an underdosed blend.**
× ~~"Clinically dosed"~~	→	✓ **Check the grams against the studies.**

CITRULLINE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Weak–moderate	$26	"Pump" blends	⇄ Plain citrulline

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HYDRATION

ELECTROLYTE PACKETS 71

SPORTS DRINKS 73

PRIME 75

HYDRATION

HYDRATION

ELECTROLYTE PACKETS

BUILT FOR THE 1%, SOLD TO THE 100%

I used to take one every single day and tell guys drinking water they were doing it wrong. Then I read the research.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL

EVIDENCE
STRONG FOR LONG, HOT SESSIONS. WEAK FOR DAILY USE.

COST
ABOUT $47/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Water isn't enough. You need electrolytes every day to stay hydrated."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Electrolyte drinks were built for real problems: severe dehydration from illness, and athletes losing huge amounts of sweat in the heat. In 2012, an investigation by the *BMJ* and Oxford examined hundreds of sports product performance claims and found the evidence behind them was weak. Sweat is less salty than your blood, so a normal workout actually concentrates your sodium. And most people already eat more sodium than recommended.

⇄ THE SWAP

Plain water for normal training. For long, hot sessions where you're soaked, a pinch of salt and a splash of juice in your bottle.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Water isn't enough"~~	→	✓ **For a normal workout, it is.**
× ~~"Optimal ratio"~~	→	✓ **There's no proven perfect ratio for everyday use.**
× ~~"Daily hydration habit"~~	→	✓ **Most people already get plenty of sodium from food.**

ELECTROLYTES

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Strong for long, hot sessions	About $47	About $45/mo	Water, or salt and juice

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HYDRATION

SPORTS DRINKS

GREAT FOR A TWO-HOUR GAME. NOT FOR A 45-MINUTE LIFT.

The sugar and sodium in a sports drink genuinely help during long, intense exercise. The problem is who's drinking them.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
STRONG (FOR LONG SESSIONS)
COST
$1.05 A BOTTLE

☆ THE CLAIM

"Better hydration and performance, for everyone."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

For exercise lasting roughly an hour or more, especially in the heat, carbs and sodium can help performance and rehydration. For a short lift or a walk, a sports drink is mostly extra sugar.

⇄ THE SWAP

Water for most sessions. Save sports drinks for long games, hot practices and endurance events.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Hydrates better than water"~~	→	✓ **Only matters in long, sweaty sessions.**
× ~~"Fuel your workout"~~	→	✓ **A 45-minute lift doesn't need it.**
× ~~"For athletes"~~	→	✓ **Mostly bought by people who aren't mid-game.**

SPORTS DRINKS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Strong (long sessions)	$31	The sugar on short days	⇄ Water

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HYDRATION

PRIME

"SPORTS HYDRATION" WITH ALMOST NO SODIUM

Sponsored by huge sports teams and sold as elite hydration. Then you read the label.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$2.50 A BOTTLE

☆ THE CLAIM

"Elite sports hydration."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Sodium is the main electrolyte you lose in sweat, and Prime Hydration has about 10 mg per bottle. Its big electrolyte number comes mostly from potassium. It also has almost no sugar, which is part of what makes a sports drink work during long exercise. It's closer to flavored water than a sports drink.

⇄ THE SWAP

Water, or a real sports drink for long, hot sessions.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Sports hydration"~~	→	✓ **Barely any sodium.**
× ~~"Electrolyte enhanced"~~	→	✓ **Mostly potassium, not the sodium you sweat out.**
× ~~"Low sugar"~~	→	✓ **Sugar is part of how sports drinks work.**

PRIME

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$75	The whole bottle	Water

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

GREENS POWDERS 79

MULTIVITAMINS 81

VITAMIN D 83

FISH OIL 85

MAGNESIUM 87

PROBIOTICS 89

ASHWAGANDHA 91

APPLE CIDER VINEGAR GUMMIES 93

SEA MOSS 95

HEALTH

HEALTH

GREENS POWDERS

AN EXPENSIVE MULTIVITAMIN WITH A PODCAST BUDGET

75 ingredients and a host you trust reading the ad every week. Here's what the ad leaves out.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK

COST
ABOUT $79–99/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"One scoop covers your nutrition, energy, immunity and gut health."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Most greens powders put their ingredients in a proprietary blend, so you can't tell if you're getting a useful dose of anything. Many of the vitamins you can see come in amounts far beyond what you need, and your body flushes the extra. Compared with a basic multivitamin, popular greens powders can come up short on minerals like calcium and magnesium.

⇌ THE SWAP

A bag of frozen vegetables. If your diet really has gaps, a basic multivitamin.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"75+ ingredients"~~	→	✓ **Doses hidden in a blend.**
× ~~"Better than a multivitamin"~~	→	✓ **Can miss key minerals.**
× ~~"Superfood"~~	→	✓ **No legal definition.**

GREENS POWDERS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$79–99	Up to about $90/mo	Frozen veg + multivitamin

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

MULTIVITAMINS

CHEAP INSURANCE, NOT A HEALTH UPGRADE

A multivitamin won't make a healthy eater healthier. But if your diet has gaps, it's a cheap safety net.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
A FEW DOLLARS A MONTH

☆ THE CLAIM

"More energy, better immunity, better health."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Multivitamins help cover deficiencies. For people who already eat a varied diet, the benefits for preventing disease are unclear. They're not an energy product.

⇄ THE SWAP

A basic, third-party-tested multivitamin. No need for "men's performance" versions.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"All-day energy"~~	→	✓ **Only if you were deficient.**
× ~~"Men's performance formula"~~	→	✓ **Often the same vitamins, priced higher.**
× ~~"Gummies are just as good"~~	→	✓ **Often lower doses and added sugar.**

MULTIVITAMINS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	A few dollars	The "performance" markup	⇄ Basic multivitamin

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

VITAMIN D

WORTH IT IF YOU'RE LOW. A BLOOD TEST TELLS YOU.

If you work indoors all day, there's a decent chance you're low.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
STRONG (IF DEFICIENT)
COST
A FEW DOLLARS A MONTH

☆ THE CLAIM

"Better immunity, mood, bones and testosterone."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Vitamin D deficiency is common worldwide, especially for people who get little sun. (Holick, 2007) Correcting a deficiency matters. If your levels are already fine, taking more doesn't add much.

⇄ THE SWAP

Get a blood test. If you're low, a basic D3 supplement at the dose your doctor suggests.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Testosterone support"~~	→	✓ **Helps mainly if you're deficient.**
× ~~"Mega-dose for immunity"~~	→	✓ **More isn't better, and too much can be harmful.**
× ~~"Everyone needs it"~~	→	✓ **Depends on your levels and sun exposure.**

VITAMIN D

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Strong if deficient	A few dollars	"T-boosters" that are mostly vitamin D	⇄ Blood test, then basic D3

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

FISH OIL

USEFUL IF YOU NEVER EAT FISH

The research is more mixed than the bottle suggests.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$17/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Heart health, joint health, brain health."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

A large trial, VITAL, didn't find that fish oil supplements reduced major heart events in the general population. It may help people who eat very little fish.

⇄ THE SWAP

Fatty fish like salmon, sardines or mackerel twice a week.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Heart protection"~~	→	✓ **Mixed results in healthy people.**
× ~~"Joint support"~~	→	✓ **Small effects at best.**
× ~~"Everyone should take it"~~	→	✓ **Food covers it for many people.**

FISH OIL

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$17	The bottle, if you eat fish	⇄ Salmon twice a week

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

MAGNESIUM

HELPS IF YOU'RE LOW. NOT A SLEEPING PILL.

A lot of people come up short on magnesium. That doesn't make it a sleep cure.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE (IF DEFICIENT)
COST
$6/MO

THE CLAIM

"Better sleep, less stress, fewer cramps."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Many people get less magnesium from food than recommended. (NIH Office of Dietary Supplements) Fixing a shortfall can help. Evidence for magnesium as a sleep aid in healthy people is weak.

THE SWAP

Nuts, seeds, beans, leafy greens and dark chocolate. If you're short, a basic supplement like magnesium glycinate.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Deep sleep formula"~~	→	✓ **Weak evidence in healthy people.**
× ~~"Everyone is deficient"~~	→	✓ **Many fall short, not everyone.**
× ~~"Sleep stack"~~	→	✓ **Often magnesium at a big markup.**

MAGNESIUM

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$6	"Sleep stacks"	⇄ Food first, basic glycinate

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

PROBIOTICS

THE RIGHT STRAIN FOR THE RIGHT PROBLEM, OR NOTHING

Effects depend on the exact strain and the exact problem. "Gut health" isn't one.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY (FOR MOST PEOPLE)
EVIDENCE
WEAK FOR HEALTHY PEOPLE
COST
$14/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Fixes your gut, boosts immunity, beats bloating."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Some strains have evidence for specific issues, like diarrhea from antibiotics. For healthy people, the benefit is unclear. See The Gut Health Craze, page 37.

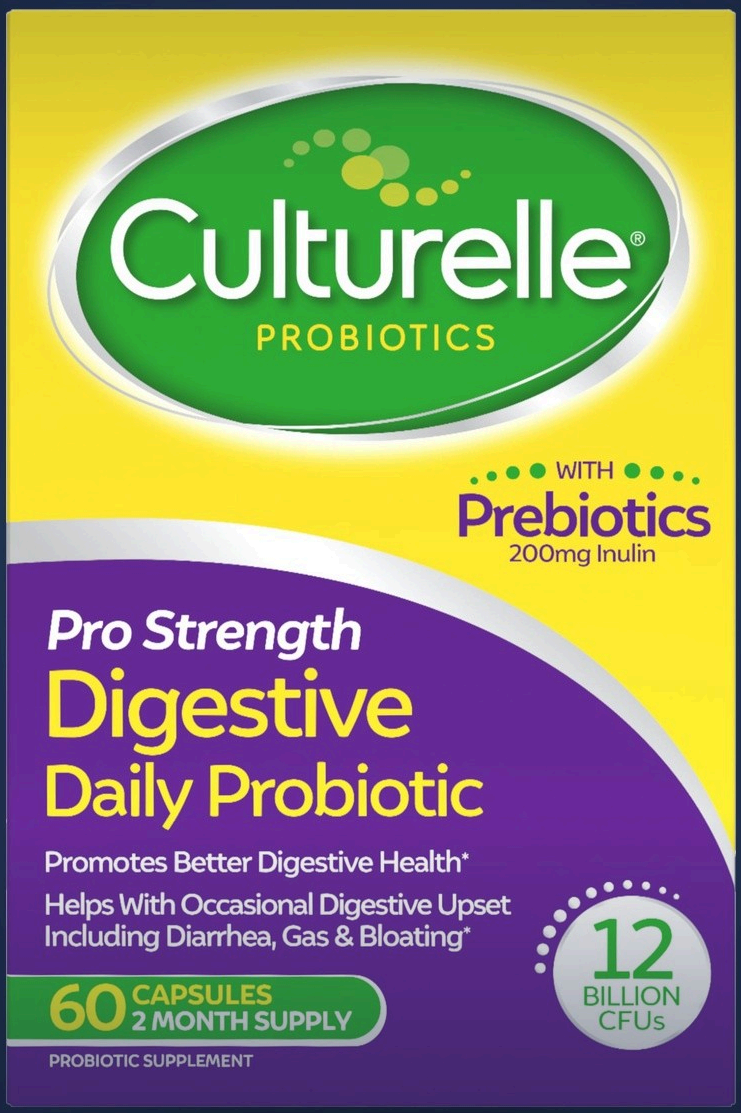
⇄ THE SWAP

Fermented foods like yogurt, kefir, sauerkraut and kimchi, plus more fiber. For a real gut issue, ask a doctor which strain, if any.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"50 billion CFUs"~~	→	✓ **A big number doesn't mean the right strain.**
× ~~"Heals your gut"~~	→	✓ **Not a diagnosis. Not a cure.**
× ~~"Take it forever"~~	→	✓ **Benefits often stop when you stop.**

PROBIOTICS



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$14	The subscription	⇅ Fermented foods + fiber

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

ASHWAGANDHA

SOME EVIDENCE FOR STRESS. NOT A T-BOOSTER.

One of the better-studied herbs, but with real caveats.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$25/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

“Less stress, better sleep, more testosterone.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

There's some evidence for stress and sleep. Testosterone benefits mostly show up in men who are already low. There have been rare reports of liver injury, and some countries have restricted it.

⇄ THE SWAP

Fix sleep and stress first. If you try it, use a third-party-tested product and stop if you notice side effects. Talk to a doctor if you have a thyroid condition or take medication.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Boosts testosterone"~~	→	✓ **Mainly in men who are low.**
× ~~"Ancient, so it's safe"~~	→	✓ **Rare liver injury has been reported.**
× ~~"Stress-proof"~~	→	✓ **Small effects, not a fix for your life.**

ASHWAGANDHA

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$25	"T-boost" blends	⇄ Sleep and stress basics

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

APPLE CIDER VINEGAR GUMMIES

CANDY WITH A WELLNESS LABEL

The evidence for vinegar is small. The dose in most gummies is smaller.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK

COST
$15/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Weight loss, detox, blood sugar control."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Studies on apple cider vinegar show small effects at best, and most gummies don't contain the amounts used in those studies. Your liver and kidneys already handle "detox."

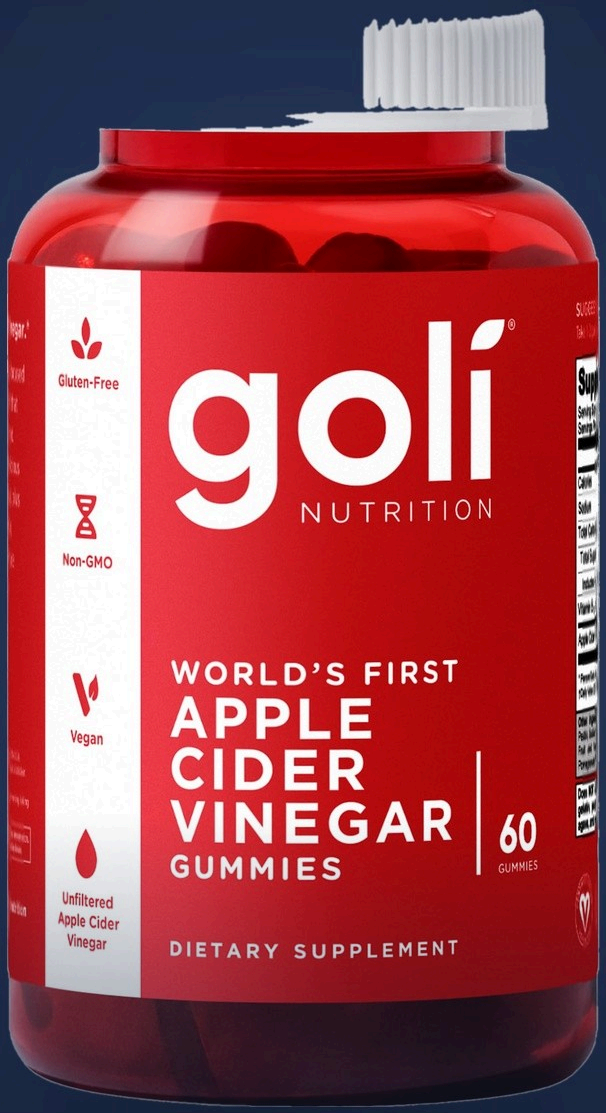
⇄ THE SWAP

Nothing. If you like vinegar, put it in a salad dressing.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Melts fat"~~	→	✓ **No meaningful evidence.**
× ~~"Detox"~~	→	✓ **Your organs already do that.**
× ~~"Nature's Ozempic"~~	→	✓ **Not even close.**

ACV GUMMIES



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$15	The whole bottle	Nothing needed

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HEALTH

SEA MOSS

"92 MINERALS" AND ALMOST NO RESEARCH

It's food. Expensive food, with a marketing story.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$30/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"A superfood packed with minerals that fixes everything."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Sea moss contains nutrients, but there's little real research on sea moss supplements. Iodine content can vary a lot from product to product, and too much iodine can affect your thyroid.

⇄ THE SWAP

A varied diet with fruit, vegetables and seafood.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
✕ ~~"92 of 102 minerals"~~	→	✓ **Mostly a marketing line.**
✕ ~~"Superfood"~~	→	✓ **No legal definition.**
✕ ~~"Thyroid support"~~	→	✓ **Too much iodine can do the opposite.**

SEA MOSS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$30	The jar	A varied diet

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

FAT BURNERS 99

SKINNY AND DETOX TEAS 101

L-CARNITINE 103

CLA 105

BERBERINE 107

SWEAT BELTS AND WAIST TRAINERS 109

FAT LOSS

FAT LOSS

FAT BURNERS

MOSTLY CAFFEINE, WITH THE WORST SAFETY RECORD IN THE AISLE

Ephedra and DNP were both sold as fat burners. That alone should make you careful.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK

COST
ABOUT $20–29 A BOTTLE

☆ THE CLAIM

"Thermogenic" formulas that torch fat."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Most fat burners rely on caffeine. The extra calories burned are small, roughly what a few extra minutes of walking would do. Fat loss comes from a consistent calorie deficit, not from a pill. This category also has the worst safety history in the industry. See page 39.

⇄ THE SWAP

A calorie deficit you can stick to. If you want the energy, coffee.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Torch fat"~~	→	✓ **Burning fat isn't losing fat.**
× ~~"Thermogenic formula"~~	→	✓ **Usually caffeine.**
× ~~"Clinically proven"~~	→	✓ **Check who was studied, and their diet.**

FAT BURNERS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$20–29	The whole bottle	Calorie deficit + walking

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

SKINNY AND DETOX TEAS

A LAXATIVE IN A NICE BOX

You'll lose weight. It just won't be fat.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$4.50 A PACK

☆ THE CLAIM

"Flatten your stomach. Detox your body."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Many contain senna, a laxative. You lose water and whatever is in your gut, not fat. Regular laxative use can cause real problems. Your liver and kidneys already do the detoxing.

⇄ THE SWAP

Peppermint or ginger tea if you just enjoy tea.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Flat tummy in 14 days"~~	→	✓ **Water and digestion, not fat.**
× ~~"Detox"~~	→	✓ **Your organs already do it.**
× ~~"All natural"~~	→	✓ **Senna is natural, and it's a laxative.**

DETOX TEA

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$8	The whole pack	↓ Regular tea

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

L-CARNITINE

THE "FAT SHUTTLE" YOU ALREADY HAVE

Carnitine does help move fat into your cells for energy. You just already make plenty.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$5/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Shuttles fat into your cells to be burned."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Healthy people already make enough carnitine. Supplementing hasn't shown meaningful fat loss in healthy, active people.

⇄ THE SWAP

A calorie deficit.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Fat transport"~~	→	✓ **Your body already does it.**
× ~~"Added to energy drinks"~~	→	✓ **Marketing, not fat loss.**
× ~~"Liquid shots work faster"~~	→	✓ **No good evidence.**

L-CARNITINE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$5	The bottle	Calorie deficit

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

CLA

A FRACTION OF A POUND, AT BEST

CLA had its moment in the 2000s. The research never caught up with the hype.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$14/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Melts belly fat."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In human studies, the effect is tiny, a fraction of a pound a week at best, and it can cause stomach upset.

⇄ THE SWAP

A calorie deficit.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Targets belly fat"~~	→	✓ **You can't spot-reduce fat.**
× ~~"Natural fat burner"~~	→	✓ **Tiny effect.**
× ~~"Keeps muscle while dieting"~~	→	✓ **Protein does that.**

CLA

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$14	The bottle	Calorie deficit

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

BERBERINE

"NATURE'S OZEMPIC" ISN'T OZEMPIC

It has some real research behind it. Just not the research the nickname suggests.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL

EVIDENCE
MODERATE (BLOOD SUGAR), WEAK (WEIGHT LOSS)

COST
$44/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"A natural version of Ozempic."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Berberine has some evidence for improving blood sugar. Studies show modest weight loss at most, nowhere near a GLP-1 drug. It can interact with medications and cause stomach issues.

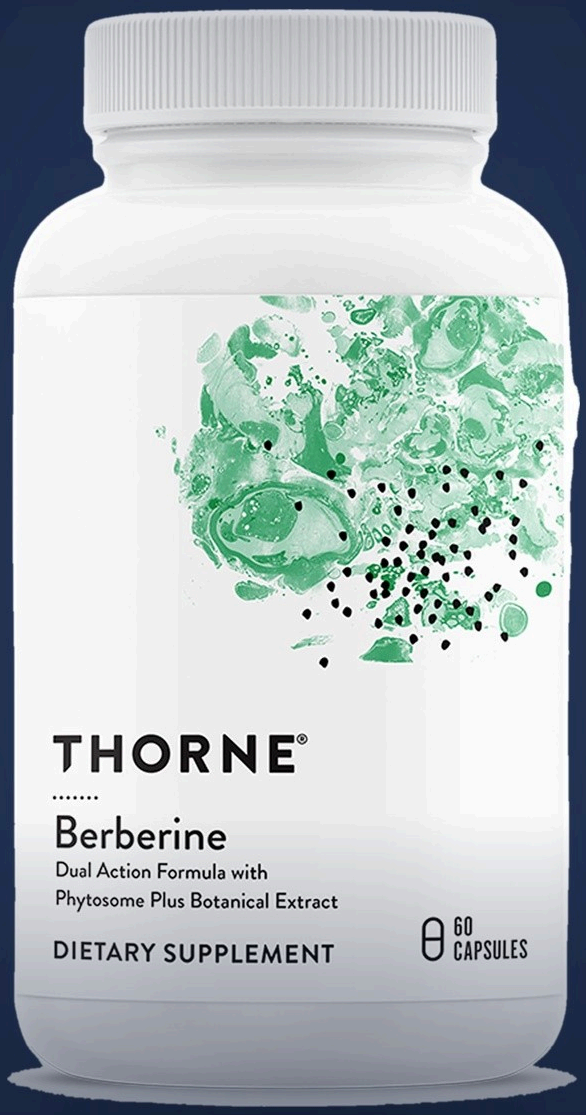
⇄ THE SWAP

If blood sugar is a real concern, see a doctor. For weight loss, a calorie deficit and protein at every meal.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
✕ ~~"Nature's Ozempic"~~	→	✓ **Nowhere near the same effect.**
✕ ~~"Melts fat"~~	→	✓ **Modest results at most.**
✕ ~~"Safe because it's natural"~~	→	✓ **It can interact with medications.**

BERBERINE



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Situational	Moderate	$44	The "Ozempic alternative" markup	Doctor, deficit, protein

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

FAT LOSS

SWEAT BELTS AND WAIST TRAINERS

THE ONLY THING YOU LOSE IS WATER

The 1970s sauna suit, now in a smaller size.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
NONE FOR FAT LOSS

COST
ABOUT $22–40

☆ THE CLAIM

"Burn belly fat while you train."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Sweating more doesn't burn more fat. It's water, and it comes back the moment you drink. You can't melt fat from one spot by heating it. Waist trainers squeeze your midsection while you wear them, and that's all.

⇄ THE SWAP

A calorie deficit and consistent training. For support on heavy lifts, a real lifting belt.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Burns belly fat"~~	→	✓ **Burns nothing extra.**
× ~~"Inches lost"~~	→	✓ **Water, back after you drink.**
× ~~"Sauna effect"~~	→	✓ **Just sweat.**

SWEAT BELTS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	None	$22–40	The belt	Deficit, or a real lifting belt

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

HORMONES

TESTOSTERONE BOOSTERS 113

TONGKAT ALI 115

"HORMONE BALANCING" SUPPLEMENTS 117

HORMONES

NUGENIX®
TOTAL-T
TOTAL TESTOSTERONE BOOSTING FORMULA
HELPS TO:
FEEL STRONGER & LEANER*
BOOST FREE & TOTAL TESTOSTERONE*
SUPPORT STRONGER DRIVE*
Dietary Supplement • 90 Capsules

☆ HORMONES

TESTOSTERONE BOOSTERS

SELLING TO THE BIGGEST INSECURITY GUYS HAVE

Most of these ingredients don't deliver. The ones that do mostly help guys who are deficient.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK FOR HEALTHY MEN

COST
ABOUT $65–70/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Naturally boost your testosterone for more muscle, energy and drive."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

D-aspartic acid showed a short bump in one study, then levels returned to normal within weeks. Fenugreek and tribulus haven't reliably raised testosterone in healthy men. Zinc, vitamin D and magnesium only help if you're actually deficient.

⇄ THE SWAP

Track your food for a week and fix real gaps. Eat enough, because long, hard diets suppress hormones. Sleep, lift and lose excess fat. Got real symptoms? See a doctor.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Clinically proven"~~	→	✓ **On paper, not in the mirror.**
× ~~"Boosts T naturally"~~	→	✓ **Mostly if you're deficient.**
× ~~"Alpha male formula"~~	→	✓ **Marketing aimed at insecurity.**

T-BOOSTERS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$65–70	About $65/mo	Food, sleep, lifting

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

☆ HORMONES

TONGKAT ALI

SIGNIFICANT ON PAPER. HARD TO FEEL IN REAL LIFE.

It has better evidence than most boosters. But think about what the numbers actually mean.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
$22/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"A proven natural testosterone booster."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Some studies show a 10–20% increase in testosterone. A guy at 600 ng/dL might reach about 700. Testosterone therapy can roughly double levels. That's the gap between "statistically significant" and something you'd notice in the gym. See page 18.

⇄ THE SWAP

The basics on the previous page will do more for most guys.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Raises T by 15%"~~	→	✓ **A change you probably won't feel.**
× ~~"Podcast-approved"~~	→	✓ **Endorsed isn't the same as proven.**
× ~~"Natural TRT"~~	→	✓ **Not even close.**

TONGKAT ALI

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$22	A change you won't notice	⇄ Fix the basics

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

☆ HORMONES

"HORMONE BALANCING" SUPPLEMENTS

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$30/MO

BALANCING WHICH HORMONE, EXACTLY?

Your body has dozens of hormones. "Balanced" means something different for each one, and for each person.

☆ THE CLAIM

“Balances your hormones.”

🔍 WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

No single supplement brings every hormone to a perfect middle. If a product won't name which hormone it changes, and how, that's your answer.

⇄ THE SWAP

If you think something is off, get blood work and talk to a doctor.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
✕ ~~"Balances your hormones"~~	→	✓ **Which ones? It never says.**
✕ ~~"Fixes fatigue and weight gain"~~	→	✓ **Those have many possible causes.**
✕ ~~"Doctor formulated"~~	→	✓ **Doesn't mean it was tested.**

HORMONE BALANCING

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$30	The bottle	Blood work + a doctor

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

MELATONIN 121

ZMA 123

COLD PLUNGE TUBS 125

RED LIGHT THERAPY 127

MASSAGE GUNS 129

INFRARED SAUNA BLANKETS 131

MOUTH TAPE 133

RECOVERY

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

MELATONIN

NOT A SEDATIVE, AND THE LABEL MIGHT BE WRONG

Melatonin can help with jet lag and a shifted schedule. It's not a nightly knockout pill.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE (JET LAG, SHIFTED SCHEDULES)
COST
$4/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Knocks you out. Better sleep every night."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Melatonin can help you fall asleep a little faster, especially when your schedule is off. And labels often aren't accurate: a 2023 *JAMA* study tested 25 melatonin gummy products and found only 3 were within 10% of the amount on the label. One had none at all. (Lee et al., 2023)

⇄ THE SWAP

A consistent bedtime, a dark and cool room, and no screens or caffeine late. For jet lag, a small dose of a third-party-tested product.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Deep sleep gummies"~~	→	✓ **Helps timing, not depth.**
× ~~"5 mg per serving"~~	→	✓ **Often not what's actually inside.**
× ~~"Take it every night"~~	→	✓ **Fix the habits first.**

MELATONIN

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$4	Nightly "sleep gummies"	⇄ A consistent bedtime

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

ZMA

ZINC, MAGNESIUM AND B6, AT A MARKUP

It only helps if you're actually low in zinc or magnesium.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY (FOR MOST PEOPLE)
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$13/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Better sleep, recovery and testosterone."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In people who aren't deficient, studies haven't shown meaningful gains in testosterone or performance.

⇄ THE SWAP

Eat enough meat, seeds, nuts and beans. If a blood test shows you're low, a basic zinc or magnesium supplement.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Anabolic sleep formula"~~	→	✓ **Basic minerals with a big name.**
× ~~"Boosts testosterone"~~	→	✓ **Only if you're deficient.**
× ~~"Vivid dreams mean it works"~~	→	✓ **That's a side effect, not proof.**

ZMA

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$13	The branded bottle	Food, or basic minerals if low

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

COLD PLUNGE TUBS

GOOD FOR SORENESS. BAD TIMING FOR GAINS.

Many people love how cold water makes them feel. Just don't jump in right after you lift.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE
COST
ABOUT $1,150–$8,000

☆ THE CLAIM

"Faster recovery and more growth."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Cold water can reduce soreness. But regular cold-water immersion right after strength training may blunt long-term gains in muscle and strength. (Roberts et al., 2015)

⇄ THE SWAP

A cold shower costs nothing. If you plunge, keep it away from your lifting sessions.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Faster recovery"~~	→	✓ **Less soreness, maybe smaller gains.**
× ~~"You need a tub"~~	→	✓ **A cold shower works.**
× ~~"Plunge after every lift"~~	→	✓ **Bad timing if muscle is your goal.**

COLD PLUNGE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$1,150–$8,000 (one-time)	Up to $8,000	A cold shower, away from lifting

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

RED LIGHT THERAPY

SOME SCIENCE, LOTS OF WEAK DEVICES

There's real research here, but the cheap gadgets often aren't strong enough to match it.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
WEAK TO MODERATE
COST
$189

THE CLAIM

“Better skin, faster recovery, more energy.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Some evidence supports properly powered devices for skin, used consistently, often several times a week. Many cheap devices are too weak to do much. For skin, daily sunscreen has far stronger evidence.

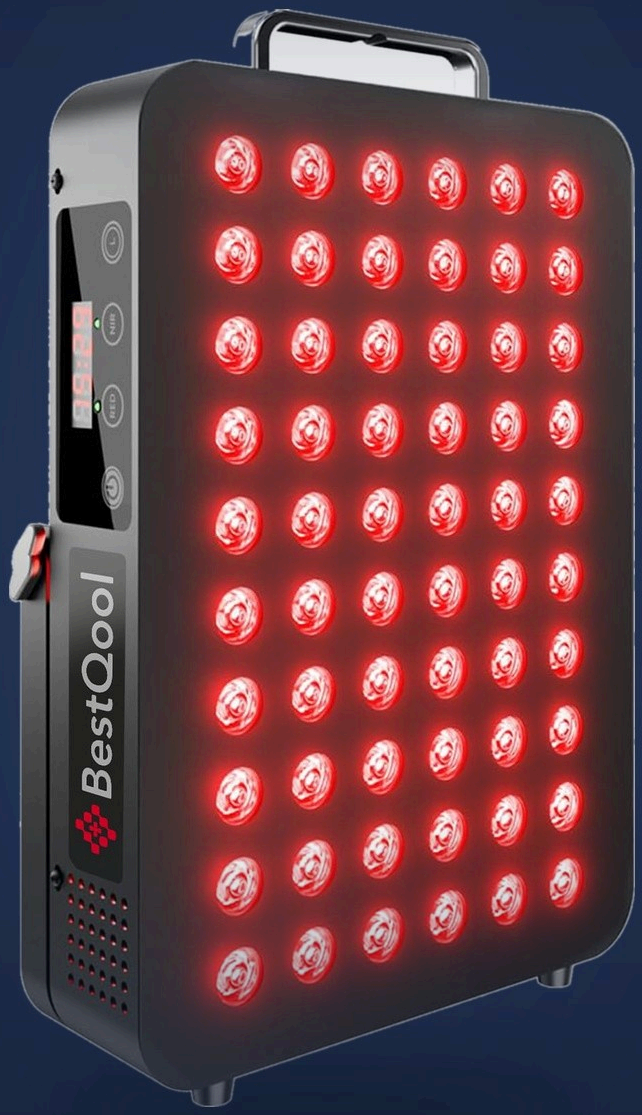
THE SWAP

Sunscreen and a retinoid for skin. Sleep and smart training for recovery.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Clinical results at home"~~	→	✓ **Depends heavily on the device's power.**
× ~~"Faster muscle recovery"~~	→	✓ **Evidence is limited.**
× ~~"Use it whenever"~~	→	✓ **Studies need consistent, frequent use.**

RED LIGHT



VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Weak–moderate	$189 once	Weak, cheap devices	⇄ Sunscreen + retinoid

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

MASSAGE GUNS

FEELS GOOD. DOESN'T HEAL YOU FASTER.

Great for the first month. Then they tend to live in a drawer.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
WEAK TO MODERATE
COST
$50–650

☆ THE CLAIM

"Faster recovery."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

They can make sore muscles feel better and may help short-term flexibility. They don't meaningfully speed up muscle repair.

⇄ THE SWAP

A foam roller or a lacrosse ball does most of the same job.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Accelerates recovery"~~	→	✓ **Feels better, doesn't repair faster.**
× ~~"Pro athletes use it"~~	→	✓ **They also have physical therapists.**
× ~~"Daily essential"~~	→	✓ **Most end up collecting dust.**

MASSAGE GUNS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Weak–moderate	$50–650 once	Most of the price	⇄ Foam roller

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

INFRARED SAUNA BLANKETS

A SLEEPING BAG THAT MAKES YOU SWEAT

Traditional saunas have research behind them. Blankets mostly don't.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK

COST
$699

☆ THE CLAIM

“Detox, fat loss, recovery.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Traditional saunas have a decent body of research, much of it from Finland. Infrared sauna blankets have very little. Sweating out water isn't fat loss or "detox."

⇄ THE SWAP

A gym or spa with a real sauna, if you enjoy it.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Sweat out toxins"~~	→	✓ **Sweat is mostly water and salt.**
× ~~"Burn 600 calories"~~	→	✓ **Mostly water weight.**
× ~~"Same as a sauna"~~	→	✓ **Much less research.**

SAUNA BLANKETS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$699 once	The blanket	A real sauna, if you enjoy it

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

SLEEP AND RECOVERY

MOUTH TAPE

A VIRAL HACK WITH REAL RISKS

If you snore or wake up exhausted, tape isn't the fix. A doctor is.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$20/MO

☆ THE CLAIM

"Better sleep, less snoring, a sharper jawline."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

A 2025 review found scant benefits and significant risks, especially for people with blocked noses or undiagnosed sleep apnea. (HealthDay, 2025)

⇄ THE SWAP

If you snore or wake up tired, ask a doctor about sleep apnea. If your nose is always blocked, get that checked.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Better sleep"~~	→	✓ **Little evidence.**
× ~~"Jawline gains"~~	→	✓ **No evidence.**
× ~~"Stops snoring"~~	→	✓ **May hide a real problem.**

MOUTH TAPE

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$20	The tape	A sleep check with a doctor

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

VIBRATION PLATES 137

"THE MACHINE MOVES FOR YOU" 139

AB GADGETS 141

LUMEN 143

FOOD SENSITIVITY TESTS 145

BODY FAT SCALES 147

SLEEP AND FITNESS TRACKERS 149

BALANCE BRACELETS 151

GADGETS

GADGETS AND TESTS

VIBRATION PLATES

THE 1920s VIBRATING BELT, WITH AN APP

Stand on it, shake, lose fat. We've been falling for this for a hundred years.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY (FOR FAT LOSS)
EVIDENCE
WEAK FOR FAT LOSS
COST
$200

☆ THE CLAIM

"Burn fat and cellulite by standing on it."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

There's some research on balance and bone health, mostly in older adults. There's no good evidence it burns a meaningful amount of fat. See 100 Years of the Same Scam, page 23.

⇄ THE SWAP

Walking, and any real workout.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Shake off the fat"~~	→	✓ **No meaningful fat loss.**
× ~~"10 minutes = 1 hour workout"~~	→	✓ **No.**
× ~~"Boosts circulation"~~	→	✓ **So does walking.**

VIBRATION PLATES

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$200 once	The plate	↑↓ Walking

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

"THE MACHINE MOVES FOR YOU"

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
OFTEN HUNDREDS OF DOLLARS

IF A MOTOR DOES THE WORK, YOU DON'T

Under-desk ellipticals that pedal themselves, waist twisters and motorized gadgets that promise results "without exerting yourself."

☆ THE CLAIM

“Get fit without working hard.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Your body adapts when your muscles do hard work. Equipment that's too easy lands in a dead zone: not heavy enough to build muscle, not long enough to be real cardio.

⇄ THE SWAP

Bodyweight squats, push-ups, rows and walking. Add dumbbells when you need more challenge.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"No sweat required"~~	→	✓ **No sweat, no results.**
× ~~"Full-body workout"~~	→	✓ **Usually one easy movement.**
× ~~"Low impact"~~	→	✓ **Low effort, too.**

THE MACHINE MOVES FOR YOU

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	Often hundreds	The gadget	Bodyweight + dumbbells

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

AB GADGETS

ABS ARE BUILT IN THE KITCHEN, NOT ON A ROCKER

You can't spot-reduce belly fat. Abs show up when your body fat is low enough.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY
EVIDENCE
WEAK
COST
$35

☆ THE CLAIM

"A six-pack in minutes a day."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Most ab gadgets just make a crunch slightly easier. Training your abs makes them stronger, but whether you can see them comes down to body fat, and that comes down to diet.

⇄ THE SWAP

Planks, hanging leg raises and cable crunches, plus a calorie deficit.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Abs in 3 minutes a day"~~	→	✓ **Abs come from low body fat.**
× ~~"Better than crunches"~~	→	✓ **Usually an easier crunch.**
× ~~"Targets belly fat"~~	→	✓ **Spot reduction doesn't work.**

AB GADGETS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	Weak	$35 once	The gadget	↑↓ Planks + a calorie deficit

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

LUMEN (METABOLISM BREATH TRACKER)

IT MEASURES SOMETHING REAL. THE PROMISE ISN'T.

The device can estimate whether you're burning more fat or carbs right now. That's not the same as losing fat.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK (FOR FAT LOSS)

COST
$299 + SUBSCRIPTION

☆ THE CLAIM

“Track your metabolism and burn more fat.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Your body balances fat and carb use over the whole day. Burn more fat in one hour, and you'll often burn less later, and vice versa. Fat loss depends on a calorie deficit over time, not on your fuel mix in the moment.

⇄ THE SWAP

A food-tracking app and a bathroom scale.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Burn more fat"~~	→	✓ **Burning fat isn't losing fat.**
× ~~"Hack your metabolism"~~	→	✓ **You can't out-breathe a calorie surplus.**
× ~~"Personalized plan"~~	→	✓ **A calorie target does the job.**

LUMEN

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	$299 + subscription	Device + subscription	Food app + scale

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

FOOD SENSITIVITY TESTS

IT TELLS YOU WHAT YOU EAT A LOT OF

Most home tests measure antibodies that rise with foods you eat often. So the results mostly read like your grocery list.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
WEAK

COST
OFTEN HUNDREDS OF DOLLARS

THE CLAIM

"Find the foods secretly holding you back."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Most home tests measure IgG antibodies, which usually reflect exposure to a food, not a problem with it. Allergy organizations advise against using IgG tests to diagnose food sensitivities.

THE SWAP

If certain foods really bother you, see a doctor or a registered dietitian about a proper elimination approach. Real allergies need real testing.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
~~"Find your hidden sensitivities"~~	→	✓ **Mostly shows what you eat often.**
~~"Lab-grade results"~~	→	✓ **Measuring the wrong thing precisely.**
~~"Personalized elimination plan"~~	→	✓ **Can cut out foods you're fine with.**

FOOD SENSITIVITY TESTS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
Waste of money	Weak	Often hundreds	The whole kit	A doctor or dietitian

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

BODY FAT SCALES

USEFUL FOR TRENDS. NOT FOR DAILY NUMBERS.

Not a scam. Just less accurate than the screen makes it look.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE (FOR TRENDS)
COST
$25

☆ THE CLAIM

"Track your body fat every day."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Home scales use bioimpedance, which can swing with how hydrated you are. The daily body fat number isn't very accurate, but the long-term trend can be useful.

⇄ THE SWAP

A regular scale, a tape measure around your waist, and progress photos every few weeks.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Precise body fat %"~~	→	✓ **Can swing several points day to day.**
× ~~"Track muscle gain"~~	→	✓ **Rough estimate at best.**
× ~~"Check daily"~~	→	✓ **Look at weekly averages instead.**

BODY FAT SCALES

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$25 once	The upgrade over a basic scale	⇄ Scale + tape + photos

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

SLEEP AND FITNESS TRACKERS

GREAT FOR HABITS. WATCH THE SUBSCRIPTION.

Useful while you're building a habit. Many people stop checking after a few months.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL
EVIDENCE
MODERATE (STEPS), WEAK (SLEEP STAGES)
COST
$130 + SUBSCRIPTION

☆ THE CLAIM

"Optimize your sleep, recovery and training."

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Trackers are good at counting steps and showing trends. Sleep stages and "recovery scores" are estimates, not lab measurements.

⇄ THE SWAP

Your phone already counts steps. If you buy one, buy it to build a habit, and check for monthly fees.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Know your recovery"~~	→	✓ **An estimate, not a diagnosis.**
× ~~"Optimize your sleep"~~	→	✓ **Going to bed earlier does more.**
× ~~"Small monthly fee"~~	→	✓ **Adds up over a year.**

TRACKERS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊖ Situational	Moderate	$130 + subscription	The subscription	⇄ Your phone

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

GADGETS AND TESTS

BALANCE AND "PERFORMANCE" BRACELETS

A RUBBER BAND WITH A HOLOGRAM

At their peak, pro athletes wore them. Then the company admitted the truth.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
NONE

COST
$14

☆ THE CLAIM

“Better balance, strength and flexibility.”

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In 2010, Power Balance told Australia's consumer watchdog, "We admit that there is no credible scientific evidence that supports our claims," and offered refunds. (SBS News, 2011)

⇄ THE SWAP

Nothing. It's a rubber band.

MARKETING VS. REALITY

THEY SAY		REALITY
× ~~"Hologram technology"~~	→	✓ **Marketing.**
× ~~"Worn by pros"~~	→	✓ **Pros get paid to wear things.**
× ~~"Feel the difference"~~	→	✓ **Placebo.**

BALANCE BRACELETS

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	COST/MO	YOU SAVE	SWAP
⊗ Waste of money	None	$14 once	The bracelet	↑↓ Nothing

AT A GLANCE

Prices checked on Amazon, Oct 2026. They change often.

PART 3: WHAT WORKED FOR ME

MY STORY 155

INVISIBLE DAY TO DAY 158

HOW I EAT 160

HOW I TRAIN 162

MY STACK AND STARTER STACKS 164

THE CHEAT SHEET 166

WHAT WORKED

225 TO 175

When I was 20, I had just stopped playing Division One baseball. I'd hurt my arm, and just like that, the sport I'd built my whole life around was gone.

So I put everything I had into my fitness. The problem was, I didn't know what I was doing.

I was 225 pounds. I was depressed, and I hated my body.

I tried everything to lose the weight. Crash diets. Fat burners. Pretty much every supplement under the sun. If someone online said it worked, I bought it.

None of it worked.

So I went back to the basics.

Back then, I DoorDashed every single meal. Wingstop. McDonald's. Fifteen cookies at a time. I was spending $50 to $100 a day on food, five or six meals a day, all of it processed. I didn't know what a calorie was. I didn't know what protein was. I just ate for pleasure.

And I threw money at products. Fat burner pills that promised to melt fat. Powders. Testosterone booster gummies. Tongkat ali, ashwagandha, anything someone online said would help me lose weight. I tried all of it, and none of it worked.

The guy who bought everything.

WHAT I'D TELL MY 20-YEAR-OLD SELF

- The basics aren't a beginner thing. They're the whole thing.
- If a product promises to make it easy, it's selling the promise, not the result.
- You're not behind. You're comparing yourself to people who aren't real.

INVISIBLE DAY TO DAY. UNDENIABLE OVER TIME.

SMALL CHANGES, REPEATED

Most people try to change everything at once: new diet, new supplements, new program, all on Monday. It feels productive. It also falls apart by Friday.

What worked for me was smaller.

- ✓ Two meals a day plus one or two snacks, which put me in a calorie deficit.
- ✓ Push-ups and sit-ups in my room, before I ever joined a gym.
- ✓ Learning how much protein I actually needed.
- ✓ One supplement at a time, only if it had real evidence.

No single change transformed me. But I kept doing them, and they added up.

A SLIGHTLY BETTER ROUTINE YOU KEEP IS WORTH MORE THAN A PERFECT ONE YOU QUIT.

I started taking creatine and locked in. Push-ups and sit-ups in my room, every day, for about five months, while eating two meals a day in a calorie deficit. That's when the weight finally started coming off, and the confidence came with it.

The moment I knew it was working? When I could finally see my top two abs. That was a huge milestone for me. And I noticed people started treating me differently once I got in shape. That stuck with me.

That is how most of my progress happened: invisible day to day, undeniable over months.

HOW I EAT

PHASE 1: THE FIRST 30 POUNDS

- Two meals a day, in a calorie deficit. No more DoorDash.
- Real food instead of fast food. Simple meals I could repeat every day.
- I didn't track perfectly. I just ate less than I burned, and I stayed consistent.

PHASE 2: THE GYM YEARS

- Protein at every single meal. Red meat, salmon, eggs. I always get my protein in now.
- Mostly protein and carbs, a few veggies in between. Want to cut? A little less food. Want to bulk? A little more. The protein never changes.

A NORMAL DAY FOR ME NOW

MEAL	WHAT I EAT	PROTEIN (APPROX.)
Breakfast	High-protein breakfast after the gym	40 g
Lunch	Pork chops or another red meat, with a carb	45 g
Snack	A protein shake if I'm short for the day	25 g
Dinner	Salmon and rice with teriyaki sauce, plus veggies	40 g

HOW I TRAIN

WHERE I STARTED: push-ups and sit-ups in my room. 100 of each, every day.

WHAT I DO NOW:

DAY	FOCUS	MAIN LIFTS
Mon + Thu	Push	Bench press, overhead press, incline dumbbell press, triceps
Tue + Fri	Pull	Pull-ups, rows, lat pulldowns, biceps
Wed + Sat	Legs	Squats, Romanian deadlifts, leg press, calves
Sunday	Rest	Walk, recover, eat

SETS AND REPS: 3 to 4 sets of 6 to 12 reps on most lifts. When I hit the top of the rep range with good form, I add a little weight next time. That's it. Push, pull, legs, repeat, six days a week.

MY RULES FOR TRAINING

- **Consistency.** Show up every single day. That's really what matters.
- **Hit every muscle group, every week.** Push, pull, legs, then do it again.
- **Your diet does most of the work.** No matter how good your training is, if your diet isn't locked in, you won't see results.

MY ENTIRE STACK

After all of it, this is everything I actually take.

SUPPLEMENT	WHY I USE IT	COST/MO
Creatine monohydrate	Strength and muscle, strongest evidence	$6
Protein powder	The easiest way to hit my protein	$50
Pre-workout	I like it, and I know the caffeine does the work	$30
Total		**$86**

That's it. Three things.

STARTER STACKS BY BUDGET

$0 A MONTH

WHAT'S IN IT

Calorie target, protein from food, lifting, sleep, walking, coffee

WHO IT'S FOR

Everyone starts here

ABOUT $10 A MONTH

WHAT'S IN IT

Everything in $0, plus creatine

WHO IT'S FOR

You train consistently

ABOUT $55 A MONTH

WHAT'S IN IT

Everything in $10, plus a tub of whey

WHO IT'S FOR

You struggle to hit protein from food

THE CHEAT SHEET

Screenshot this. Use it in the store.

✓ WORTH IT (4)

- ✓ Whey protein
- ✓ Plant protein (if needed)
- ✓ Creatine
- ✓ Caffeine

⊖ SITUATIONAL (21)

- ⊖ Protein bars and snacks
- ⊖ Collagen
- ⊖ Mass gainers and meal replacements
- ⊖ Pre-workout
- ⊖ Beta-alanine
- ⊖ Citrulline
- ⊖ Electrolyte packets
- ⊖ Sports drinks
- ⊖ Multivitamins
- ⊖ Vitamin D
- ⊖ Fish oil
- ⊖ Magnesium
- ⊖ Ashwagandha
- ⊖ Berberine
- ⊖ Tongkat ali
- ⊖ Melatonin
- ⊖ Cold plunge tubs
- ⊖ Red light therapy
- ⊖ Massage guns
- ⊖ Body fat scales
- ⊖ Sleep and fitness trackers

× SKIP IT (22)

- × BCAAs and EAAs
- × Prime
- × Greens powders
- × Probiotics (most people)
- × Apple cider vinegar gummies
- × Sea moss
- × Fat burners
- × Skinny and detox teas
- × L-carnitine
- × CLA
- × Sweat belts and waist trainers
- × Testosterone boosters
- × "Hormone balancing" supplements
- × ZMA (most people)
- × Infrared sauna blankets
- × Mouth tape
- × Vibration plates
- × "The machine moves for you"
- × Ab gadgets
- × Lumen
- × Food sensitivity tests
- × Balance bracelets

WHEN IN DOUBT

WATER.
COFFEE.
CREATINE.
PROTEIN.
SLEEP.

Each product has its own spread with the research, the costs and the swap. Check the page number in the contents.

CLOSING WORDS

I started making videos because I was tired of being sold to. Then I realized almost everyone I knew was being sold to in the same way, and most of them didn't know it.

This guide took five years of my own trial and error to research, and six months to write. Every verdict in here is one I'd stand behind if you asked me about it in person.

If even one page saves you from a product you didn't need, or the years of frustration I went through, it did its job.

THE BIGGEST THANK-YOU GOES TO YOU.

Buying this guide helps me keep doing what I do: longer investigations, better videos and more time digging into the research instead of chasing sponsors.

I don't take sponsorships so I can tell you the truth. You're the reason I can afford to.

Boon

A FEW MORE THANK-YOUS BEFORE WE CLOSE OUT:

- My parents, for supporting me through my entire fitness journey.
- My close friends, who had my back through every stage of it.
- And myself, for putting in the work when nothing was working.

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INDEX

A

Ab gadgets – 141
Apple cider vinegar gummies – 93
Ashwagandha – 91

B

Balance bracelets – 151
BCAAs and EAAs – 61
Berberine – 33, 107
Beta-alanine – 59, 65
Body fat scales – 147

C

Caffeine pills – 63
Citrulline – 67
CLA – 105
Cold plunge tubs – 125
Collagen – 51
Creatine – 57

D

DMAA – 39
DNP – 39

E

Electrolyte packets – 71
Ephedra – 23, 39

F

Fat burners – 99
Fish oil – 85
Food sensitivity tests – 145

G

Greens powders – 79
Gut health – 37

H

"Hormone balancing" supplements – 117

I

Infrared sauna blankets – 131

L

L-carnitine – 103
Lumen – 143

M

Magnesium – 87
Mass gainers and meal replacements – 53
Massage guns – 129
Melatonin – 121
Mouth tape – 133
Multivitamins – 81

O

Ozempic – 33

P

Peptides – 31
Physique inflation – 25
Plant protein – 47
Pre-workout – 59
Prime – 75
Probiotics – 89
Protein bars and snacks – 35, 49

R

Red light therapy – 127

S

SARMs – 27
Sea moss – 95
Skinny and detox teas – 101
Sleep and fitness trackers – 149
Sports drinks – 73
Steroids – 27
Sweat belts and waist trainers – 109

T

"The machine moves for you" – 139
Testosterone boosters – 113
Tongkat ali – 115
TRT – 29

V

Vibration plates – 23, 137
Vitamin D – 83

W

Whey protein – 45

Z

ZMA – 123

// The fine print

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// Where the photos came from

IMAGE CREDITS

PRODUCT PHOTOS. Manufacturer product images as shown on their Amazon.com listings (amazon.com/dp/ID): ON Gold Standard Whey B000GISTZ4, Orgain B00J074W7Q, Quest B07J2MM23Z, Vital Proteins B00K6JUG4K, ON Creatine B002DYIZEO, C4 B01N25BZXJ, XTEND B005CH0DT4, Nutricost Caffeine B01DFQSVK6, NOW Beta-Alanine B0017KU74Q, NOW L-Citrulline B001B4P3UQ, LMNT B07TT8B1JJ, Gatorade B00HC767P6, PRIME B0DLYJG96G, Centrum Men B09BW24R2B, Doctor's Best B000BD0RT0, Culturelle B08Y66H6B7, Gaia Herbs B003HD9H0G, Goli B07R8GD47V, EverSmith B08CGCH1RQ, Hydroxycut B01NAXDNE6, Yogi DeTox B0009F3SAK, Nutricost L-Carnitine B06Y1BTLGK, Sports Research CLA B01F2OG8B8, Thorne Berberine B009LI7VRC, Sweet Sweat B017AGGBTU, Nugenix B0CYHFRLGV, Nootropics Depot B088GQDV76, DIM for Men, Natrol B08666GMWG, Nutricost ZMA B01NCMN6WL, AirOutelle cold plunge, BestQool B07ZCDDLDN, TheraGun B0CG2G7RQY, HigherDOSE B09M8YQ4KB, Napify mouth tape, Lifepro B07P5GV3VX, Allwolf ab stimulator, Everlywell B085648CRJ, RENPHO B01N1UX8RW, Fitbit B0CC62ZG1M, Power Balance B0GT7HZ8ZJ, Bowflex B0FRNG2N5H, Thorne Creatine B07978VPPH, Lenny & Larry's B086QNNL78, OLIPOP B0DWHVFK7S, BlenderBottle B07TK681SZ, Owala B0BZYCJK89, TriggerPoint B00K06I222, Apple iPhone B0CMZ8ZBVN, Apple Watch B0HJBCGY95, syringe B0BNG6C52W, blood tubes B0D22WTWYC, vials B0GRVXFZD3, scale B0C4DTW586.

BRAND WEBSITES. Optimum Nutrition Serious Mass (optimumnutrition.com). Lumen device photo (lumen.me press page). AG1, Nature Made and Ab Roller images supplied by the author.

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OTHER PHOTOS. Meal prep (p12) and Liver King (p19) images supplied by the author and used with permission for commentary. Liver King is referenced as a public figure in reporting cited in the Sources section.

COMPOSITES. The cover and pages 7, 8 and 24 combine several of the product photos listed above.

CORRECTIONS. Spotted a credit that's wrong or missing? Contact the author and it will be fixed in the next update.

// YOUR NEXT STEP

YOU KNOW WHAT WORKS. NOW MAKE IT WORK FOR YOU.

This guide tells you what to stop wasting money on. The next part is doing it: the right food, the right training and the 2 or 3 supplements that actually matter for **you**. Here are two ways I can help.

FREE · 2 MINUTES

GET YOUR STACK SCORE

Tell me what you take. You'll get a score out of 100, what to cut and how much you're wasting every month.

GET MY FREE STACK SCORE →

1:1 COACHING WITH ME · 12 WEEKS

THE SIX-PACK STACK

Your supplements audited, a meal plan built from food you actually like, a training app and a check-in with me every week. **Abs in 12 weeks, or I coach you free until you get there.**

SEE IF YOU QUALIFY →

GUYS I'VE COACHED

−30+ lbs
Robert · 3 months

−40 lbs
Gerardo · 4 months

+10 lbs muscle
James · 4 months

RESULTS VARY. SPOTS ARE LIMITED SO I CAN CHECK IN WITH EVERY CLIENT MYSELF.

BEYOND THE LABEL

THE TRUTH BEHIND WHAT YOU'RE BUYING.

The supplement industry doesn't need to prove its products work before it sells them. So I did the work instead.

This is a full investigation of 47 fitness products and the 7 biggest trends: what the label claims, what the research actually shows, my verdict and the cheaper thing that does the same job.

No sponsors. No affiliate links. No discount codes.

It's also the system that took me from 225 to 175 pounds, without a single product doing the heavy lifting.

47 PRODUCTS INVESTIGATED

FOR FAT LOSS, MUSCLE GAIN & YOUR WALLET

FF